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Himalayan Linguistics

A Sketch of the Sampang Language

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ABSTRACT

This work is a grammatical sketch of the Sampang language, an endangered language belonging to the Kiranti branch of the Trans-Himalayan (Sino-Tibetan) language family. It is the first published work to cover all aspects of grammar, including phonology, morphology, syntax and lexicon. Like many Kiranti languages, Sampang has extremely complex verbal morphology, displaying both subject and object agreement as well as intricate morphophonological alternations, and a substantial portion of the sketch is devoted to these issues. Other points of linguistic interest include the syntax of case and agreement, and the nature of linking morphs in the language. Some notes are made on the lexicon of the language, which displays thoroughgoing contact phenomena and an unusually rich array of motion verbs.

KEYWORDS

Sampang; Kiranti; Grammar Sketch; Phonology; Syntax; Morphology

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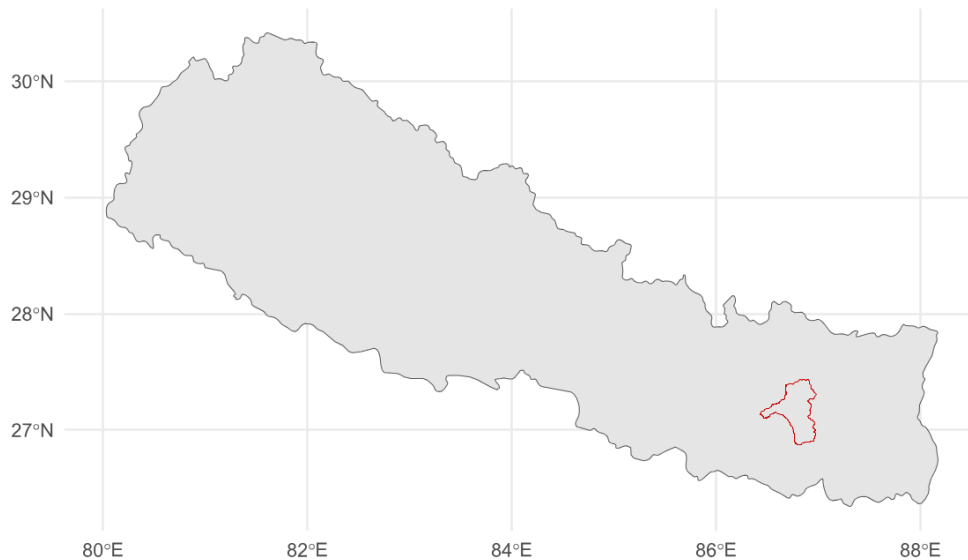
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1 Introduction

Sampang (Sampang:/sampaŋ/, ISO 639-3: rav) is a Central Kiranti language (cf. Hanßon 1991, van Driem 2001, Bickel and Gaenszle 2015, Grollmann and Gerber 2018) spoken by the Sampang Rai people, primarily in the valley of the Ṭāp Kholā in Nepal’s Khotang district.¹ The core language area is located in Kepilāsgaḍhī Rural Municipality and Diktel Rupakoṭ Majhuwāgaḍhī Urban Municipality, specifically within the wards (formerly Village Development Committees) of Phedi, Pāthekā, Khārtāmchā and Bāspānī, each of which encompasses a number of settlements.

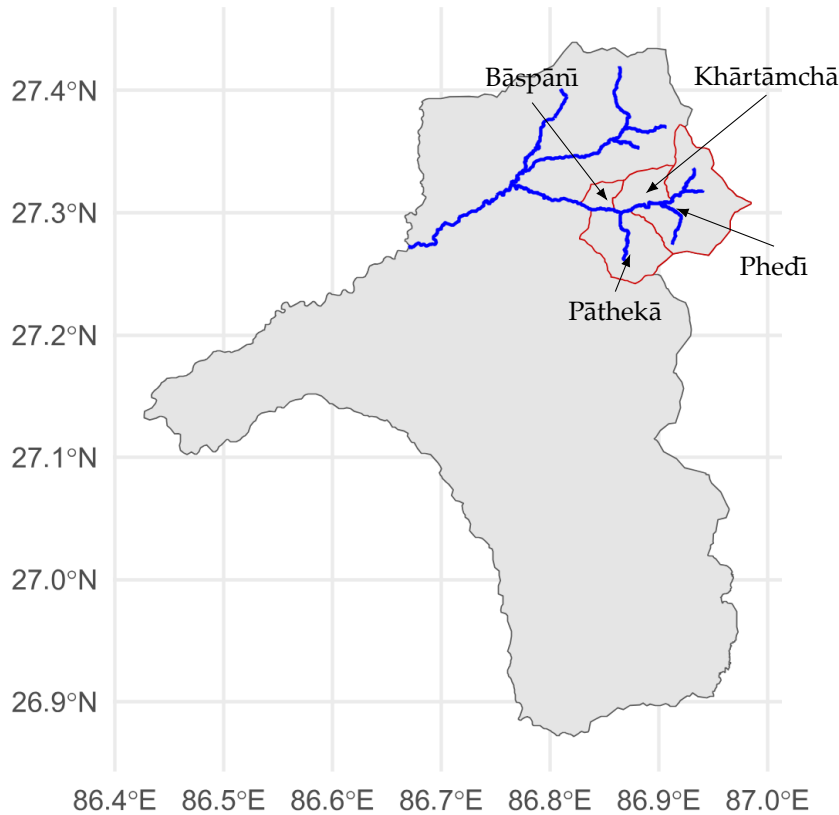
The location of the Sampang speaking area is illustrated in (1) and (2): in (1), Khotang district is highlighted in red, while on the map of Khotang district in (2), the wards where Sampang is spoken are highlighted in red, and the local river system (including the Ṭāp Kholā) is highlighted in blue.

(1) *Location of Khotang district within Nepal*



¹Thanks go first of all to the Sampang community, and in particular my main consultants Harichandra Sampang Rai and Munga Dhan Sampang. Many thanks to them for sharing their knowledge with me with good humour, patience and hospitality. Thanks also to Darius Adjong, Robert Marcelo Sevilla and Rupachandra Rai for their assistance during a fieldtrip to Khoṭāṅg district in 2025. Thanks to a number of Sampang speakers for lending their voices to the Sampang corpus, including Chaturmani Rai, Dimba Sampang Rai, Deebya Rai, Arun Prasad Rai, Hastaram Sampang Tomihā, Dhik Bahadur Sampang, Sagunkala Sampang, Chitamani Sampang Rai, Chitrakumari Sampang, Subhamaya Rai, Kumarsingh Rai, Sharki Dhan Sampang, Chabirat Sampang, Partiman Sampang Rai and Utra Prasad Sampang. Many thanks to two anonymous reviewers for their detailed and helpful comments, and to audiences at the University of Hong Kong, the Chinese University of Hong Kong, the Polytechnic University of Hong Kong, the University of Manchester and the University of Cambridge for useful feedback. Any remaining errors are of course my sole responsibility. This work was partially supported by the Hong Kong Research Grants Council grant “Description of the Sampang Language”.

(2) Location of Sampang-speaking area in Khotang district



Sampang Rai settlements are found outside this area, especially in neighbouring Bhojpur district, but speakers state that the language is no longer spoken in these areas. Hanßon (1991) and Cho (2020), however, identify language islands with remaining speakers in other districts, in particular including Dhankuta and Ilam, which I have not yet been able to investigate further. The language is endangered – while the language is spoken quite robustly by individuals in their 30s and older, younger members of the community tend to be at most passive users of the language. Contact with Nepali is intense and speakers of all ages make use of extensive code-mixing with Nepali. Some teaching of the language takes place in local schools, and textbooks are available in the language for the first two years of primary school (e.g. Rai and Rai 2022).

Sampang is also spoken by a large diaspora community – the sketch here is largely the result of ongoing work (since 2020) with two speakers of Sampang, one in their 30s and one in their 50s, both born in what is now Phedī ward, but now living in Kathmandu and Hong Kong, respectively. They are both regular users of the language with relatives and other members of the Sampang community. This is supplemented by data from a small collection of recordings gathered in Kathmandu and the Ṭāp Kholā valley.²

This description largely casts Sampang in its own terms rather than in a broader Kiranti context, in part to ensure that the analysis is synchronically motivated by the facts of Sampang itself rather than its historical relationship to other Kiranti languages. I do, however, make occasional reference to other Kiranti languages, especially Sampang's close relative Kulung. These examples, where not otherwise cited, are drawn from Tolsma's (2006) grammar. For some discussion of Sampang's historical links with other Kiranti languages, see Perry and Sevilla (in prep.).³

²On the data used in this paper: where an example comes from a (quasi-)spontaneous connected text, the title of the text together with the date of recording is given. It is envisioned that recordings of these texts will be made available online in the near future. If an example is not accompanied by a citation along these lines, it is derived from direct, translation-based elicitation. Directly elicited utterances are referenced if the stimulus was taken from an external source (in particular, Dahl 1985).

³A reviewer notes an article in press by Selin Grollman which also touches on these topics, rigorously establishing the subgrouping relationship between Kulung, Nachhiring and Sampang.

Existing work on Sampang includes two short articles by Huysmans (2006, 2011), a simple dictionary (Wong 2006), a discussion of the morphosyntax of nominals in the language (Rai 2009), an number of masters theses on agreement (Rai 2007, Rai 2018, Rai 2020), a comparison of lexical items across neighbouring Kiranti groups (Rai 2013), a sociolinguistic survey and wordlist (Rai et al. 2015), a description of the agreement system of an isolated dialect in Dhankuta (Cho 2020) and a discussion of agreement in ditransitives (Perry 2024). This is in addition to some older material, including a vocabulary list (Hodgson 1856), a glossed text (Wolfenden 1933) and some sketchy grammatical notes (Konow 1909). The work here has generally been developed independently of previous descriptions, and differs from them on some points, which will be highlighted occasionally.

The sketch is laid out by grammatical module, beginning with phonology in §2, where I deal with the phonological inventory, phonotactics, and morphophonology. In §3 I introduce the morphology of nouns and related categories, including pronouns and other pro-forms, numerals, case-markers, and nominal derivation. I then move on to some other categories that are often connected to nominal forms, including localising elements (akin to postpositions) in §4 and discourse particles in §5. I discuss verbal morphology in §7, including verbal agreement, tense and aspect, the syntax of copular forms, auxiliaries and non-finite verbs. I discuss the syntax of Sampang in §8, with a particular focus on the syntax of case, agreement and word order. Finally, in §9 I provide some brief notes on some aspects of the Sampang lexicon, in particular borrowed vocabulary and motion verbs.

2 Phonology

In most of what follows I will describe the phonology of the Sampang *native* vocabulary (i.e. vocabulary of Proto-Kiranti origin, or otherwise where there is no obvious source for an item). However, Sampang is in intense contact with Nepali, and as such has acquired a very large number of loanwords, with varying degrees of nativisation. These loanwords sometimes show distinct phonological patterning – in particular, Nepali has a less restricted syllable structure than Sampang, and a more robust distinction between certain consonant categories (e.g. between breathy-voiced and modal voiced consonants, or between dental and retroflex stops). These properties are reflected in the loanword vocabulary of Sampang. This is discussed in more detail in Section 2.4. In general, I use IPA symbols to express the phonological contrasts of Sampang – note however that this is a broad phonemic transcription rather than a phonetic one.⁴ There are a few instances where the phonetic realisation of a phonological sequence deviates from the pronunciation the transcription here would suggest, which are noted in this section.

2.1 Inventory

Sampang has a native inventory of 21-27 consonants, including 9-13 stops, 3-4 affricates, 2 fricatives, 3-4 nasals (where variability depends on the robustness of a breathy voice distinction in a given idiolect) and 4 approximants. This is coupled with an inventory of six vowel qualities together with an oral-nasal contrast (which is however only robustly distinctive in native vocabulary for a single vowel in the inventory). The inventory is broadly similar to the Nepali inventory, with the primary differences being the absence of retroflex consonants, except in Nepali borrowings and a single native lexical item, and the variable status of the breathy/modal voicing distinction in stops and affricates).

2.1.1 Consonants

Stops and Affricates Sampang contrasts (in native vocabulary) three places of articulation (labial, dental, velar) in stops plus one in affricates (denti-aveolar). A single native lexical item, *qʰjappa* ‘big’ variably displays a retroflex initial.⁵ These consonants also display a three- or four-way contrast in laryngeal setting (voiceless aspirated, voiceless unaspirated, modal voiced, with a dialectally variable contrast with breathy voiced/voiced aspirated).

⁴An exception is that I use the ordinary Latin ⟨g⟩ rather than the strict IPA ⟨g̱⟩, for ease of typesetting.

⁵I suspect that the realisation with the retroflex form is a sort of expressive enhancement, and that the item should be analysed as having an alveolar initial in the unmarked case. My consultants state that this is the only item with a retroflex stop.

(3) *Stops and Affricates in Sampang*

	Labial	Dental	Denti-alveolar	Velar
Plain Voiceless	p	t	ts	k
Aspirated Voiceless	p ^h	t ^h	ts ^h	k ^h
Modal Voiced	b	d	dz	g
Aspirated Voiced	b ^{fi}	d ^{fi}	dz ^{fi}	g ^{fi}

The distinction between modal voiced and aspirated voiced consonants appears to be somewhat unstable. In some subvarieties the distinction appears to be collapsed, generally speaking in favour of the breathy-voiced alternant.⁶ The distinction is, however, preserved robustly in words borrowed from Nepali (see Section 2.4). Minimal pairs for place and laryngeal setting are shown below – I have restricted myself here to cases where exact minimal pairs are available *and* where sounds are featurally close enough to require justification of a contrast.

(4) *Minimal pairs of stops and affricates by place of articulation*

t vs. ts	te-ma ‘put-INF’	tse-ma ‘teach-INF’
b vs. d	bubu ‘older brother’	dudu ‘milk; breasts’
t vs. k	tã ‘hair’	kã (1SG)

(5) *Minimal tuples of stops and affricates by laryngeal setting*

t vs. t ^h vs. d ^{fi}	te-ma ‘put-INF’	t ^h e-ma ‘kick-INF’	–	d ^{fi} e-ma ‘fell-INF’
ts vs. ts ^h	tsa ‘cooked rice’	ts ^h a ‘child’	–	–
ts ^h vs. dz ^{fi}	–	ts ^h Λ-ma ‘deliver-INF’	–	dz ^{fi} Λ-ma ‘throw-INF’
p vs. b	po ‘tree’	–	bo ‘belly’	–
b vs. b ^{fi}	–	–	bul-ma ‘get angry-INF’	b ^{fi} ul-ma ‘run-INF’

Fricatives Sampang has two fricatives, a voiceless coronal fricative /s/ and a breathy-voiced glottal fricative /fi/. Minimal pairs of /s/ with /ts/ and /ts^h/, as well as zero-initial forms, are shown below:

(6) *Minimal pairs involving fricatives*

s vs. ts vs. ts ^h	sa ‘meat’	tsa ‘rice’	ts ^h -a ‘become-PST’
fi vs. Ø	fi oi-ma ‘demolish-INF’	oi-ma ‘snap-INF’	

Nasals Nasals show a three-way place distinction (labial, coronal, velar) /m, n, ŋ/. A single example of a distinctive breathy counterpart has been found, in the form m^{fi}o-ma ‘to fight’ (contrast mo-ma ‘to do’).⁷

Minimal pairs among nasals are shown below:

(7) *Minimal pairs among nasals*

n vs. ŋ	nabΛ ‘ear’	ŋabΛ ‘face’
n vs. m	nana ‘older sister’	mama ‘mother’
m vs. ŋ	japs-u-m ‘hit-PST.3O-1PLS’	japs-u-ŋ ‘hit-PST.3O-1SGS’

Below are minimal pairs between nasals and similar non-nasal sounds (e.g. voiced stops and approximants).

⁶In the tables that follow I indicate the realisations I have directly observed, preserving the distinction if possible. One of my main consultants generally collapses the distinction, while the other keeps them distinct.

A reviewer suggests that, as the emergence of a breathy-voicing contrast in Kiranti varieties is often attributed to contact with Indo-Aryan languages, the variety that lacks the distinction should be treated as conservative. I do not believe this is correct – the major reason being that breathy-voicing in Sampang generally (though not exceptionlessly) corresponds to breathy voicing in related languages such as Bantawa (Doornenbal 2009) and Chamling (Ebert 2001). As such the breathy-voicing contrast is reconstructible to the common ancestor of these languages, and the variety that lacks the distinction is at least ‘locally’ innovative. This is discussed in further detail in Perry and Sevilla (in prep.)

⁷This is only a minimal pair for some speakers, as we have alternative forms for both words, e.g. m^{fi}kã-ma ‘fight’, mu-ma ‘do’.

(8) *Contrast between nasals and stops or approximants*

ŋ vs. g ^(h)	ŋi-ma ‘know-INF	g ^(h) i-ma ‘laugh-INF
m vs. b ^(h)	rim-ma ‘surround-INF	rib-ma ‘tie_together-INF’
n vs. d ^(h)	ne-ma ‘read-INF’	d ^(h) e-ma ‘fell-INF’
m vs. w	ɦΛ-ma ‘break-INF	ɦΛwa ‘skin’
n vs. l	nam ‘sun’	lam ‘road’

Approximants In addition to semivowels /j/, /w/, Sampang has an alveolar tap (occasionally realised as a trill – for convenience we will note this phoneme as /r/) and a lateral alveolar approximant /l/. Some minimal pairs among approximants are shown in (9):

(9) *Contrasts among approximants*

j vs. w	jal-ma ‘rub-INF’	wal-ma ‘play-INF’
j vs. l	j̃Λ ‘what?’	l̃Λ ‘leg’
j vs. r	jab-ma ‘serve-INF’	rab-ma ‘block-INF’
w vs. l	w̃Λ-ma ‘enter-INF	l̃Λ-ma ‘say-NPST.3O.1SGS-CONV’
w vs. r	ts ^h ̃Λwa ‘bird’	ts ^h ̃Λra ‘goat’
l vs. r	lim-ma ‘be.sweet-INF’	rim-ma ‘surround-INF’

Below are minimal pairs between approximants and similar stop sounds:

(10) *Contrasts between approximants and stops*

l vs. d ^(h)	lai-ma ‘go up’	d ^(h) ai-ma ‘go down’
w vs. b ^(h)	wa ‘chicken’, ‘rain’	b ^(h) a ‘earth’

2.1.2 *Vowels*

Monophthongs Sampang has six contrastive vowel qualities /a, i, u, e, o, ʌ/, together with a nasalisation distinction. This is identical to the Nepali vowel inventory. Vowels display an allophonic tense/lax alternation, with tense alternants [a, i, u, e, o, ʌ] appearing in open syllables and lax alternants [ɐ, ɪ, ʊ, ɛ, ɔ, ə] appearing in closed syllables. Nasalisation is contrastive, but phonemically oral vowels often show some gradient nasalisation in nasal environments (e.g. following nasal stops).

Minimal pairs for oral vowels can be seen in (11):

(11) *Vowel minimal pairs*

/a/ vs. /ʌ/ vs. /e/	japs-ʌ ‘hit-NPST.3O’	japs-a ‘hit-PST[1PLS]’	japs-e ‘hit-NPST.1O’
/e/ vs. /i/	ims-e ‘sleep-1PL’	ims-i ‘sleep-NPST[3SG]’	
/i/ vs. /u/	m-i ‘do-NPST[3O.3SGS]’	m-u ‘do-PST.3O’	
/u/ vs. /o/	ɦu ‘hand’	ɦo ‘cop’	
/o/ vs. /a/	k ^h o (3SG)	k ^h a ‘matter’	
/o/ vs. /ʌ/	b ^h o-ma ‘help-INF’	b ^h ʌ-ma ‘cook-INF’	

Minimal contrasts for nasal vowels are harder to find – we can see a robust distinction between /ʌ/ and /̃ʌ/ (e.g. the 1st person past object <-̃ʌ> vs. the 3rd person non-past object marker <-ʌ>), but other nasal vowels are quite rare in native vocabulary. This is likely for historical reasons – nasal vowels in Sampang are largely derived from historic V+ŋ clusters: contrast Sampang /k̃ʌ/ ‘tooth’ with /kan/ in closely related Kulung. Non-high vowels undergoing nasalisation were neutralised as /̃ʌ/ (cf. Sampang /t̃ʌ/ ‘hair’, Kulung /ton/), and deletion did not occur in the presence of high vowels (cf. Sampang /nun/ ‘name’, Kulung /nin/).⁸

⁸A reviewer states that these forms are exceptional and that Kulung regularly loses final velar nasals without the nasalisation observable in Sampang. I am not convinced of this. It is true that, given the forms in Tolsma (2006), nasalised forms in Sampang often

Diphthongs The only attested monomorphemic phonetic diphthongs end in [i] or [u]. As such it is difficult to tell whether they are better analysed as true vowel-vowel sequences or as vowel-glide sequences. Since it simplifies the description of the syllable structure of Sampang, we will assume the latter, and will discuss these sequences in the section on phonotactics. They will nonetheless be typically transcribed as /i/ or /u/, in part to match their conventional transcription in Devanagari orthography.⁹

We also see occasional vowel-vowel sequences across morpheme boundaries. A particularly salient example appears in the 1st person plural pronoun *ka-(j)e*, which is transparently composed of a 1st person pronominal stem *ka-* and a 1st person-specific plural marker *-(j)e* (which also appears in e.g. possessive forms and verbal morphology). Speakers sometimes prefer to write this form with a glide in the initial position of the suffix, but this glide is not always perceptible.

2.2 Phonotactics

Word-internally, clusters of up to two consonants are tolerated across a syllable boundary, as are consonant-glide clusters in syllable-initial position, giving a maximally complex syllable CGVC. The range of syllable structures found in Sampang is illustrated (12).¹⁰

(12) *Syllable structures found in Sampang*

Structure	Example	Gloss
V	i =maɬhina	one=month
VC	um =sira	3SG.POSS=head
CV	k^ho	3SG[ABS]
CGV	mj-u	do-PST.3O
CVC	suŋ	wood
CGVC	kjab -ma	sting-INF

Consonant-glide sequences are most common as a result of hiatus-eliminating operations over morpheme boundaries, but do occasionally occur in other contexts.

Only sonorants and unaspirated stops are permitted in syllable-final position. Monomorphemic diphthongs appear only in open syllables, suggesting that they should be analysed as a vowel-glide sequence.

Sampang generally does not tolerate word-final consonants, with the notable exception of nasal consonants /ŋ, m/ (e.g. /nuŋ/ ‘name’, /rum/ ‘salt’) and the labial stop /p/ (e.g. /wakep/ ‘grass’). If we count diphthongs as vowel-glide sequences, we could also add /j/, e.g. /pɬi/ ‘neck’.

Where vowel hiatus appears across morpheme boundaries, it is usually eliminated by one operation or another, but these configurations are very occasionally tolerated.

correspond to oral vowels in Kulung (e.g. Sampang /ts^hāwa/, Kulung /c^howa/ ‘bird’; Sampang /kāwa/, Kulung /kawa/ ‘water’, etc.). This is especially frequent in verbal forms. I believe this represents a difference between polysyllabic and monosyllabic forms, however. In my data, all monosyllabic nouns ending in a velar nasal or nasal vowel in Sampang end in a velar nasal in Kulung, where a cognate relation is clear. Additional examples include Sampang /luŋ/, Kulung /luŋ/ ‘stone’ (contrast Sampang /luŋma/ ‘liver’, Kulung /luma/); Sampang /lā/, Kulung /lon/ ‘leg, foot’; Sampang /bābā/, Kulung /boŋ/ ‘uncle (father’s younger brother)’, Sampang /dā/, Kulung /-don/ ‘year’; Sampang /suŋ/, Kulung /siŋ/ ‘wood’.

⁹Devanagari is the script that is used to write Nepali, and is also the script that speakers are most likely to use to write Sampang. There is, however, also some symbolic use of the Śrijaṅgā script, which is often used to write Limbu and other Kiranti languages.

¹⁰I have not been able to find any tautomorphemic CGV syllables.

Heterosyllabic Clusters Clusters at syllable boundaries are permitted in Sampang. The first member of these clusters is always an unaspirated (but not necessarily unvoiced) stop or a sonorant. Examples of the possible syllable-final consonants involved in these clusters are shown in (13), drawing from infinitive forms of verbs.

(13) *Syllable-final consonants in clusters*

Consonant	Example	Gloss
/m/	lam-ma	‘seek’
/n/	min-ma	‘think, remember’
/ŋ/	fiuŋ-ma	‘wait’
/r/	tsur-ma	‘be sour’
/l/	wal-ma	‘play’
/j/	k ^h ai-ma	‘go’
/b/	ts ^h ab-ma	‘write’
/p/	lap-ma	‘catch’
/k/	k ^h ik-ma	‘be bitter’

A few gaps will be noted here – we see no words with syllable-final /d/, /g/ or /w/, and words with syllable-final /t/ are very rare. It is interesting to note that we see syllables ending in /b/, even though other voiced stops are not licit. As discussed in Perry and Sevilla (in prep.), these tend to correspond to stem-final Proto-Kiranti *-pt in verb stems. It is not clear whether all of these gaps are systematic or accidental – however, there is an almost entirely regular alternation between /t/ and /j/ in stem final position (for which see section 2.5), which suggest that at least the absence of alveolar stops is not accidental.

Geminate consonants (i.e. sequences of two identical consonant) may be considered a type of heterosyllabic cluster.

2.3 Stress

Sampang has a stress system – some previous description can be found in Huysmans (2011). The description given here was developed independently, and disagrees at various points with Huysmans’ analysis. In particular, I was not able to reproduce some of Huysmans’ proposed minimal pairs for stress (e.g. *in-ma* ‘sell-INF’ vs *in-ma* ‘hear-INF’, which I observe to have the same stress pattern). It is likely that some of these differences in perception are a result of interactions between stress and intonation, discussed briefly in what follows, and a more thorough investigation should disentangle these issues.

2.3.1 Stress Cues

Stress assignment in languages of Nepal is difficult to analyse instrumentally due to its complex interaction with intonation. A detailed study of stress cues in Sampang remains to be completed, but I believe some broad generalisations can be made, with cues similar to those seen in other languages of the region, in particular Nepali, though these systems themselves are not well-studied.¹¹

In general, there does not seem to be a strong association between stress on the one hand and length or intensity on the other. Rather stress primarily manifests through contextually determined pitch features. In an unfocused word in the interior of an intonational phrase (which generally speaking maps to a clause), this is generally a pitch *trough* – that is to say, the stress-bearing syllable generally has the lowest pitch. This is typically accompanied (in nominals) by a stem-final high pitch. In focused elements, however, the stress-bearing element displays a pitch *peak*. In the final position of an intonational phrase, the stressed syllable marks the end of a pitch plateau, after which the pitch (in the default case) declines to a final low

¹¹The only detailed description of Nepali stress patterns appears to be that of Acharya 1993, who defines stress simply in terms of *loudness*, which does not seem to be correct given his proposed stress positions. Within Kiranti languages, descriptions often omit discussion of stress altogether, and even where they do discuss it (e.g. van Driem 1993 for Dumi, Bickel 2003/2017 for Belhare, Sharma 2015 for Puma, Paudyal 2015 for Chintang, Schackow 2015 for Yakkha, Hildebrandt 2007 for Limbu), no descriptions of the phonetic cues for stress are generally given. In his grammar of Bantawa, Doornenbal (2009) mentions as an aside that the ‘weak word stress’ is ‘realised in higher pitch and greater amplitude’.

pitch. This is the usual cue for verbal stress. Many other intonational patterns may be observed which may modify various aspects of this picture.

The default stem-final high that appears internally in the intonational phrase may be misperceived as marking stress, and I believe that this may account for some of the discrepancies between the account given here and that of Huysmans.

The proposed stress facts below are, however, largely based on impressionistic judgements. As such they should be taken to be provisional pending a thorough instrumental investigation.

2.3.2 Verbal Stress

The verbal system of Sampang shows variable, but non-contrastive positioning of the main stress. In general, stress falls on one of the last three syllables of the verbal complex. In the generic case, in words with an even number of syllables, we see stress on the penultimate syllable, while in polysyllabic words with an odd number of syllables, it falls on the antepenultimate syllable.¹² This pattern can be seen for example in the forms of the verbs *imma* ‘sleep’ and *jamma* ‘hit’:

(14)	Disyllabic	'imsa	‘They (sg.) slept’
	Trisyllabic	'imsatsi	‘They (du.) slept’
	Tetrasyllabic	imsa'tsina	‘You (du.) slept’
	Pentasyllabic	japsa'tsikana	‘You (sg.) hit us (du.)’

This relatively simple pattern is complicated by the existence of stress-attracting syllables. For example, in the paradigm of *imma*, 1st person singular and 1st person plural suffixes attract stress, resulting in e.g. final stress where penultimate would be expected, or penultimate stress where antepenultimate stress would be expected.

(15)	1sg	im'sã	‘I slept’
	1pl inc	im'se	‘We (pl. inc.) slept’
	1pl exc	im'seka	‘We (pl. exc.) slept’

It appears to be possible to define stress-attracting syllables phonologically, albeit not straightforwardly as a natural class: they include closed syllables, syllables ending with the nasal vowel /ã/, and syllables ending in /e/.

2.3.3 Nominal Stress

Nominal stress in Sampang is relatively simple – clitics (including possessive proclitics, together with case and number enclitics) are unaccented, so that accent always falls on the noun stem. Within the noun stem, if all syllables are light, stress falls on the initial syllable. If the final syllable is heavy (i.e. with a final consonant) and the initial syllable is light, stress falls on the final syllable. If there are two heavy syllables, stress falls on the later one. Examples are given in (16):

(16)	'mina	‘person’
	'sjelama	‘tomorrow’
	ri'ram	‘body’
	san'gun	‘star’

2.4 Lexical Stratification

Nepali loans (and, to a lesser extent, English loans) in Sampang are extremely widespread, and have a number of phonological properties which distinguish them from the native vocabulary of the language. These differences include differences in syllable structure (Nepali loans have a wider range of syllable-final

¹²This system can be relatively straightforwardly formalised in the terms of the analysis of Idsardi (2009). This is what Idsardi describes as an R2LIS system, with left-headed feet and accentuation of the final foot head. Stress-attracting syllables can then be analysed as inserting a leftward foot boundary to their left.

consonants, as well as initial C+r and C+l clusters), and in the phonemic inventory – Nepali loans have a robust contrast between breathy-voiced/voiced aspirated and modal voiced stops, and additionally contrast retroflex from dental stops. These loans do, however, generally respect Sampang’s ban on most word-final consonants, repairing consonant-final words with a nativising suffix *-a*: in fact, this suffix appears even in loans which would be expected to be phonotactically well-formed in Sampang, such as *kam-a* ‘work-FV’, which has a word-final /m/.¹³

2.5 (Morpho)-phonological alternations

Like most Kiranti languages, Sampang displays complex morphophonology in its verbal system. The nominal system, by contrast, shows no special morphophonology.

2.5.1 Verb stem alternations

Sampang verbs typically display two stems, a preconsonantal stem and a prevocalic stem.¹⁴ For example, we can contrast the infinitive form of the verb *jam-ma* ‘to hit, beat’ with the non-past form (with 3rd person singular arguments) *japs-a*. As is common in Kiranti languages, there are a very wide range of possible stem alternations. Let us first focus on those forms which have a consonant-final stem before vocalic suffixes.

(17) Verb Stem Alternations in Sampang

Pre-C	Pre-V	Gloss
tal-	tal-	‘reach’
ɦʌ-	ɦʌs-	‘send’
k ^h ai-	k ^h at-	‘go’
t ^h e-	t ^h et-	‘lift’
k ^h e-	k ^h it-	‘buy’, ‘break’
lai-	lat-	‘go out, go down’
te-	tis-	‘put [in]’
b ^ɦ ul-	b ^ɦ us-	‘run’
bai-	b ^(ɦ) an-	‘come’
ne-	nin-	‘speak’
op-	ops-	‘set (of sun)’
po(k)-	pok-	‘stand up’
ka(ts ^h o)-	kats ^h -	‘call’
k ^h ã-	k ^h aŋ-	‘look’
wã-	waŋ-	‘enter’
t ^h ʌ-	t ^h aŋ-	‘come up’
ŋʌ-	ŋak-	‘ask for, beg’

Some of these alternations may be analysed as purely phonological – for example, in general neither /s/ nor /t/ are found in syllable-final position in native vocabulary.¹⁵ It is plausible, then, that the alternation observed with these elements is the result of a synchronic phonological strategy eliminating these elements in closed syllables. This would be coupled with a process eliminating /i/ following front vowels – a process which was certainly active diachronically: compare Sampang *le* vs. Kulung *lei* ‘day’.

¹³My speculation is that this suffix, while originally phonologically motivated, has since been reanalysed as a general nativising suffix, and the phonotactic role it plays is now secondary.

¹⁴A reviewer asks whether there are verbs with more than two stems. With consonant-final stems, the answer is negative, modulo a degree of metaphony discussed later in this section. With vowel-final stems, the answer depends in part on our analysis of hiatus-induced alternations. With the exception of the verb *mo-ma* ‘to do’, it is generally possible to produce an analysis which assumes only two stem alternants. The same reviewer suggests that it might be desirable to reconstruct an underlying form for each verb – synchronically, this is not straightforward, due to tuples like *op~ops-* ‘set’, *jam~japs-* ‘hit’ and *im~ims-* ‘sleep’, *lap-* ‘catch’, *lam-* ‘seek’, where an underlying form for *jam~japs-* in particular is difficult without a substantial degree of abstraction. Typically, however, comparison with reconstructions such as Jacques (2017) shows that the prevocalic stem is more conservative, and likely represents the historic form in most cases.

¹⁵A single exception can be observed – /lut-ma/ ‘swallow’ displays /t/ in syllable-final position. It seems likely that this is due to taboo avoidance – the regular alternation between /t/ and /j/ would lead to a collapse with the verb /lui-ma/ ‘to fuck’.

(18) *Regular phonological changes in Sampang verbs*

- a. $t \rightarrow i / __\sigma$
- b. $s \rightarrow \emptyset / __\sigma$
- c. $i \rightarrow \emptyset / V_{\text{-back}} __\sigma$

Other processes are restricted to particular items – for example, a number of stems show vowel alternations which are not observable across the board – a particularly clear example is the contrast between ‘go up’, (Pre-C) *lai-*~(pre-V) *lat-*, which shows an /a/~/Λ/ alternation and ‘take up’ (Pre-C) *lai-*~(pre-V) *lat-*, which shows no such alternation. This cannot be analysed as a simple opposition between underlying /a/ and /Λ/ due to the existence of forms like *nai-*~*nat-* ‘like’. Another common vowel alternation which is restricted in scope is /e/~/i/, as in *k^he-*~*k^hi-* ‘buy’, ‘break’. As can be seen from (17), this process does not apply in examples like *t^he-*~*t^het-* ‘lift’.

Some consonant alternations are similarly variable. For example, while it is common for /n/, like /t/, to alternate with preconsonantal /i/ (or zero, after front vowels), this is by no means exceptionless, as we can see from examples like *min-* ‘think’, which occurs both preconsonantly and prevocally. Another sporadic alternation includes /k/~/∅/, which may even be variable within a single stem (the verb *pok-* ‘stand up’ has both variants *po-* and *pok-* preconsonantly, in apparently free/idiolectal alternation). Some alternations are only attested by a few stems, including /l/~/s/ in (pre-C) *b^hul-*~(pre-V) *b^hus* ‘run’, /m/~/ps/, as in (pre-C) *jam-* vs. (pre-V) *japs-* ‘hit, beat’.

As can be seen from the examples in (17), a common pattern in Sampang is that we see a vowel-final stem preconsonantly but a consonant emerges prevocally. In some cases, however, no such consonant emerges, although we may see alternations in the nature of the final vowel. I call these V-V stems, and analyse these cases as involving vowel-final stems both in pre-C and pre-V position.

(19) *Some V-V stems in Sampang*

Pre-C	Pre-V	Gloss
pi-	pi-	‘give’
gu-	gi-	‘say’
mu-	mi-/mu-	‘do’
t ^h a-	tso-	‘eat’
lo-	lu-	‘say’
lo-	lo-	‘feel’
t ^h Λ-	t ^h a-	‘bring up’
jΛ-	jΛ-	‘feed’
t ^h e-	t ^h i-	‘kick’

However, Sampang generally does not tolerate vowel hiatus. Various repairs eliminate the hiatus configuration that would result from combining V-V stems with vowel-initial suffixes:

- For intransitive verbs, we generally see deletion of stem vowels other than /i/. For example, compare the infinitive *ts^hu-ma* ‘to become’ with the 3sg past form *ts^h-a* ‘[they (sg.)] became’. A final stem vowel /i/, on the other hand, is typically realised as a glide – compare infinitive *gu-ma* ‘say’ with 3sg past *gj-a* ‘[they (sg.)] said’.
- This gliding process also appears with transitive verbs when following suffix is in an open syllable, e.g. infinitive *pi-ma* ‘to give’ vs 3sg→3sg past *pj-u* ‘[they (sg.)] gave [it to them (sg.)]’.
- We also see gliding of final /u/ before the past tense marker /a/.
- If the marker is in a closed syllable, we instead see deletion of the suffixal vowel, hence the third-person past tense object marker *-u* is deleted in 1sg→3sg *pi-η* ‘[I] gave [it to them (sg.)]’.
- We also see deletion of the suffixal vowel following /o/, whether in an open syllable or not, as for example in 3sg→3sg past *tso* ‘[they (sg.)] ate [it]’.
- On the other hand, deletion after /o/ does not appear in closed syllables, where instead the stem vowel is deleted, as in *ts-u-η* ‘[I] ate [it]’.

- If two identical vowels appear adjacent to each other, one of them is deleted, but it is not always clear which. This bleeds processes such as gliding.
- After nonhigh unrounded vowels (i.e. /ʌ/ and /a/), hiatus may be repaired by incorporating a second vowel /u/ or /i/ into a diphthong. In the verb *to-ma* ‘to see’, the vowel is unrounded to permit this repair, so that we see forms like *tʌ-i-na* (see-NPST-2). This only occurs in open syllables, failing which the suffixal vowel is deleted.
- In cases other than those already mentioned, we see deletion of the stem vowel.

These various repairs are summarised in (20).

(20) *Hiatus repairs*

Name	Description	Environment	Example
Identical vowel deletion	$V_{\alpha}V_{\alpha} \rightarrow V_{\alpha}$	across the board	$tu+u \rightarrow t-u$ see-PST.3O
i-gliding	$i \rightarrow j$	open syllables	$pi+u \rightarrow pj-u$ give-PST.3O
u-gliding	$u \rightarrow w$	before /a/	$tu+a+na \rightarrow tw-a-na$ see-PST-2
Closed syllable suffix deletion	$u \rightarrow \emptyset$	after an unrounded vowel in a closed syllable	$j\lambda + u + \eta \rightarrow j\lambda-\eta$ feed-PST.3O-1SGS
Suffix deletion after /o/	$u \rightarrow \emptyset$	following /o/ in an open syllable	$tso+u \rightarrow tso$ eat-PST.3O
Diphthong incorporation	$V_2]_{\sigma}V_2 \rightarrow V_1V_2]_{\sigma}$	where V_1 is a nonhigh unrounded vowel in open syllable and V_2 is a high vowel	$j\lambda + u \rightarrow j\lambda-u$ feed-PST.3O
Stem vowel deletion	$V \rightarrow \emptyset$	stem vowels, elsewhere	$tu+\lambda \rightarrow t-\lambda$ see-NPST.3O

The dummy verb *mo-ma* ‘to do’ appears to be unique in having two different prevocalic stems, depending on whether the following marker indexes an animate object or not. If it does, we optionally have the pre-V stem *mi-*, but otherwise see *mu-*.

In some cases these vowel-final stems are associated with additional unexpected allomorphy. For example, some vowel-final stems ending in /o/ and /u/ have the suffix *-i* in their non-past tense forms with 3rd person objects, a form we would more usually expect with intransitive verbs, rather than the expected transitive suffix *-a*, as in *ts-i* ‘[they (sg.)] (will) eat [it]’. This is blocked in the presence of the 1st person subject suffix *-ŋ* (realised as nasality on the vowel *-a* – see next section), so that we see *ts-ĩ* ‘[I] (will) eat [it]’, not **ts-i-ŋ*.

In addition to the alternations triggered by consonant- or vowel-initial suffixes, verb stems undergo metaphonic vowel-alternations triggered by following affixes. For example, before [-back, -low] vowels, the (pre-vocalic) stem of the verb *tse-ma* ‘teach’ has the form *tset-*, but takes the form *tsjat-* elsewhere. The preconsonantal stem of the verb *mo-ma* ‘to do’ undergoes a similarly conditioned alternation between *mo-* and *mu-*. These processes, however, appear to be variable – some speakers have them while others do not.

Some phonological alternations appear to involve free variation. For example, an intervocalic /ŋ/ is often realised as [w], with concomitant nasalisation of the following vowel. For instance, the word /bunja/ ‘flower’ is often realised as [buwã].

2.5.2 Verb affix alternations

Verbal affixes also interact with one another morphophonologically. For example, we do not see multiple affixes surfacing if they would create a hiatus configuration – for instance, the first person singular suffix $\tilde{a}$ does not co-occur with non-past tense suffix $-i$ in forms like *ims- $\tilde{a}$* (sleep-1SG), cf. 2nd person singular *ims-i-na* (sleep-NPST-2) or 3rd person singular *ims-i* (sleep-NPST).

Besides this, we also see morphologically conditioned alternations in vowel *quality*. This may be conditioned either regressively or progressively. For example, the dual subject marker $-tsu$ causes the preceding non-past tense marker (usually $-i$) to be realised as $-u$, as in *japs-u-tsu* (hit-NPST-DUS) ‘We/you/they [du.] hit them’. This alternation fails to apply in transitive verbs which take $-i$ as their non-past marker with 3rd person objects, so that we see *ts-i-tsu* (eat-NPST-DUS) ‘[We/you/they (du.)] eat [it]’, not **ts-u-tsu*. The same alternation appears with the 2nd person plural transitive subject marker $-num$.

On the other hand, the 1st person object marker $-e$ causes the dual subject marker itself to be realised as $-tsi$, as in *japs-e-tsi* (hit-NPST.1SGO-DUS) ‘They [du.] hit us [inc.]’.

Another series of interactions between affixes involves the reduplication or reordering of affixes on the basis of phonological properties. Specifically, the first syllable following most aspectual markers is reduplicated, so that it also appears before the aspectual marker, adjacent to the verb stem. For example, the form *japs-u- η -dur-u- η* (hit-PST.3O-1SGS-COMPL-PST.3O-1SGS) ‘[I] have already hit [them (sg.)]’ reduplicates both the past tense 3rd person object marker and the 1st person subject marker, as they belong to the same syllable. The target of this process is entirely phonologically conditioned, not being sensitive to the meaning of the reduplicated syllable – we see reduplication of whole object markers, parts of object markers, combinations of object and subject markers, as well as simple tense markers.

(21) Reduplication in Sampang

Target	Example	Gloss
Object marker	japs- u -dur-u	hit-PST.3O-COMPL-PST.3O
Object marker + subject marker	japs- u-η -dur-u- η	hit-PST.3O-1SGS-COMPL-PST.3O-1SGS
Part of object marker	japs- u -dur-u-tsi	hit-PST.3O-COMPL-PST.3O-NSG
Tense marker	japs- a -dur-a-na	hit-PST-COMPL-PST-2

These instances of reduplication do not always result in surface identity between the element before the aspectual marker and the element following it. This is because the reduplication process appears to feed the hiatus reduction processes detailed in (20). Hence we see examples like *tso-dur-u-tsi* (eat(PST.3O)-COMPL-PST.3O-NSG) ‘[They (du/pl.)] ate [it]’, where the third person object marker is deleted in hiatus. Note that although there is no overt reduplicant, the reduplication process must still be taken to have applied, as a vowel-initial reduplicant has triggered the prevocalic form of the verb stem here (the preconsonantal form of ‘eat’ is *tsa-*).

We do not see reduplication in the case of the progressive marker $-fi\tilde{a}$, but the *placement* of this marker is phonologically conditioned in the same way – it always appears after the first syllable of the suffixal string, regardless of the actual contents of that string, e.g. *japs-i-fi $\tilde{a}$ -na* (hit-NPST-PROG-2) ‘[They (sg.)] are hitting [you]’, *japs-a-m-fi $\tilde{a}$* (hit-NPST.3O-1PLS-PROG) ‘[We (pl.)] hit [them]’.

Another set of reduplicative processes is so-called ‘nasal reduplication’, a process with variants appearing across the Kiranti family (see e.g. Zimmermann 2016 for some discussion), which in Sampang primarily affects first person singular markers. The most frequent this environment this occurs in is if there is a nasal first person singular marker in a form also containing a number marker, when the nasal suffix is reduplicated either side of the number marker. This is independent of whether the first person argument is a subject or an object.

For example, if we have a first person singular subject and a third person non-singular object, we obtain the form *japs-u- η -tsu- η* (hit-PST.3O-1SGS-NSG-1SGS) ‘[I] hit [them (du/pl.)]’. It will be observed that the first person subject marker appears twice, once before the non-singular object marker, and once after it. It will also be observed that this modifies the colouring of the non-singular object marker – we have $-tsu-$ instead

of the expected *-tsi-*.¹⁶ Similarly with a 1st person singular object, we see examples like *japs-ã-mu-ŋ* (hit-PST.1SGO-3PLS-1SG) ‘[They (pl.)] hit me’, with the nasality (but not the actual full form) of the 1st person object marker being realised both before and after the 3rd person plural marker *-mi-* (with concomitant vowel colouring). This form can also be seen with the intransitive first person singular subject marker in the reflexive paradigm – this is because the reflexive paradigm contains a spurious number marker *-tsi-*. When combined with a first person singular subject, we see forms such as *jam-n-ã-tsu-ŋ* (hit-REFL-1SG-REFL.NUM-1SG) ‘[I] hit myself’, with a nasal element both before and after the spurious number marking.

A similar process occurs with an applicative morph when preceded by a stem ending in /u/, e.g. *mu-ŋ-pi-ŋ* (do-1SG-APPL-1SG). Contrast e.g. *k^he-pi-ŋ* (buy-APPL-1SG).

3 Morphology of nouns and pro-forms

Nominal morphology in Sampang is a relatively simple agglutinative system, with nominal stems complemented by clitics expressing case, number and possession. This section summarises these facts, as well as discussing pro-forms in general.

3.1 Pronouns and other pro-forms

3.1.1 Personal pronouns

Personal pronouns in Sampang contrast for person (1st, 2nd, 3rd), number (singular, dual and plural) and, in the case of 1st person non-singular forms clusivity (inclusive/exclusive).¹⁷

(22) *Personal Pronouns in Sampang*

	Sg	Du	Pl
1inc	(N/A)	katsi	ka(j)e
1exc	kã	katsika	ka(j)eka
2	ana	anatsi	anani
3	k ^h o	k ^h otsi	

As can be seen, first and second person pronouns contrast for all three number values, but third person forms only make a singular/non-singular contrast. A distinction between dual and plural *is* made in the verbal agreement system, however.

The 2nd person plural form may also be used as a polite 2nd person pronoun, even when referring to a single individual.

(23) *Honorific use of 2pl*

anani jãta tu-i-ni
2PL how sit-NPST-2PL

‘How are you?’ (said to one person)

3.1.2 Possessive clitics

In addition to the full pronominals in (22), Sampang possesses a range of pronominal clitic elements which express possession when attached to a following noun.

(24) *Possessive clitics in Sampang*

	Sg	Du	Pl
1inc	(N/A)	atsu=	e=
1exc	ã=	amtsuka=	amka=
2	am=	amtsu=	amnum=
3	um=	umtsu=	

¹⁶As discussed in §2.1.2, this reflects a historical process in Sampang – compare Sampang *nuŋ* vs. Kulung *niŋ* ‘name’.

¹⁷As discussed in §2.1.2, the 1pl forms are typically transcribed by speakers as possessing a glide, but this glide is not generally perceptible in speech.

These may also be used in lieu of subject marking with infinitive forms (see §8.2.3), and may also be attached to certain locational elements. Their non-selectivity in this respect is the main reason these are analysed as clitics rather than affixes. They are also used in the formation of reflexive pronouns, to which we now turn.

3.1.3 Reflexive pronouns

Reflexive pronouns result from the combination of the possessive clitics in (24) with the form *-mfĩpa*. The resulting forms are shown (25):

(25) *Reflexive pronouns in Sampang*

	Sg	Du	Pl
1inc	(N/A)	atsu=mfĩpa	e=mfĩpa
1exc	ĩ=fĩ̃pa	amtsuka=mfĩpa	amka=mfĩpa
2	am=fĩ̃pa	amtsu=mfĩpa	amnum=fĩ̃pa
3	um=fĩ̃pa	umtsu=mfĩpa	

The initial /m/ of the suffix is deleted following another nasal element. These forms may be used either as arguments or as adjuncts (meaning something like ‘by [one]self’).

3.1.4 Demonstrative pro-forms

Sampang has quite a large range of demonstrative forms. Sampang demonstratives display a basic two-way distance-based distinction, between proximal (near the speaker) and distal (far from the speaker). They also make ‘geomorphic’ distinctions (taking a term from Bickel (1997), Schackow (2015)) on the basis of the vertical direction (upwards or downwards) of the referent or the presence of a salient boundary (e.g. a river, a wall, etc.). Typically only one of these is expressed at once, so that direction and boundaries are neutralised for distance-based demonstratives, while distance is neutralised for direction- or boundary-based demonstratives, etc.

Demonstrative pronouns, which may also be used adjectivally, typically end in an element *-ka*. This element resembles the *linker* which appears in ‘participial’ verb forms and attributive adjectives, and given the adjectival use of these elements one may suspect that this is not coincidental. A table of demonstrative pronouns is given in (26):

(26) *Distance-based demonstrative pronouns*

	Form	Gloss
Prox	nakka	‘this’
Dist	makka	‘that’

(27) *Direction-based demonstrative pronouns*

	Form	Gloss
Upwards	mutuka	‘that.above’
Downwards	muinika	‘that.below’

(28) *Boundary-based demonstrative pronouns*

Form	Gloss
mekka	‘that.beyond’

These forms may be used referentially or attributively:

(29) *Use of Demonstratives*

a. *Attributive use*

makka	mina	ɲas-a-ka	wadi
that	person	fry-NPST.3O-LNK	egg
‘The egg that that person will fry’			

b. *Referential use*

maka=sã ts^h-i
that=too become-NPST
 ‘That is also ok.’

Locative demonstrative pro-forms (i.e. ‘here’, ‘there’) are similar in form to corresponding demonstrative pronouns, but do not generally involve the ‘linker’ element *-ka*, instead combining directly with case clitics (particularly the locative case marker *-pi*). For example ‘there’ is *ma**pi* and ‘here’ is *na**pi* (realised by some speakers as *napi*).

3.1.5 Interrogative and indefinite pro-forms

Interrogative and indefinite meanings are typically expressed with the same proforms, and also show a close relation to demonstrative forms. A list of interrogative forms is shown in (30):

(30) *Interrogative pro-forms*

Form	Gloss
asa	‘who’
jã	‘what, which’
jãta(ka)	‘like what’
jãtama	‘how’
fapi	‘where’
fiallo	‘when’
d ^h ã	‘why’
d ^h aika	‘how big, how much, how many’

These forms have an indefinite reading when followed by the inclusive focus marker *-sã* ‘also, even’ - typically the appropriate translation in these circumstances is as a negative polarity item (anything, anyone, etc.) or a free relative indefinite (whatever, whoever, etc.). In the latter case we often also see the conditional clitic =d^hã surfacing between the proform and the inclusive focus marker.

Some of these forms may also be reduplicated to yield positive polarity items (something, someone, etc.):

(31) *Reduplicated positive polarity items*

Form	Gloss
jã~jã	what~what = ‘something’
asa~asa	who~who = ‘someone’

This does not appear to be a fully productive strategy, however. In one instance a consultant uses a reduplicated Nepali form *kaile~kaile* (when~when) to mean ‘sometime’, but states that using the analogous Sampang form *fiallo~fiallo* would not be felicitous with this meaning.

3.2 Number marking

Sampang nouns make a simple morphological contrast between singular and non-singular. This distinction is expressed using the number marker *-tsi*, which cliticises to noun phrases.

3.2.1 Numerals

Apart from *itta* ‘one’, Sampang’s numerals are typically borrowed from Nepali, also reflecting the simple Nepali classifier system (with two classifiers, a non-human classifier *-wa**ta* and a human classifier *-dz**ana*, along with an open class of nouns used as ‘massifiers’ representing measures of mass nouns). They typically do *not* occur together with the non-singular number marker *-tsi*, and the latter is omitted if a numeral is present.

When combined with a classifier or massifier, *itta* ‘one’ takes on a proclitic form *i=*.

Native Sampang numerals are attested for higher quantities (e.g. *fisa* ‘two’, *sumka* ‘three’) but are often not known to speakers and are treated as learned vocabulary, typically not found in connected speech.

3.3 Case marking

Sampang has a range of case clitics. Arguments of verbs usually display one of three core cases (here labelled Absolutive, Ergative/Instrumental, and Dative). In addition there is a Genitive case, which appears on nominal modifiers, and a range of other oblique cases (Locative, Ablative, Comitative), which typically (though not exclusively) form adverbial elements. These are expressed using the following suffixes.

(32) Case suffixes in Sampang

Absolutive	Ø
Ergative/Instrumental	=wa
Dative	=lai
Genitive	=mi
Locative	=pi
Ablative	=ka
Comitative	=lo

For some further discussion of case usage, see §8.3. It is interesting to note that the dative form is borrowed from Nepali. Loan of this item is in fact relatively common among languages of Nepal. To give just three examples, similar borrowing is seen in the Tibetan variety Gyalsumdo (Perry 2016), Ghachok Gurung (Glover 1974) and the Kiranti language Bantawa (Doornenbal 2009).

Pronouns have some special forms in case inflection – for example, the third person singular pronoun has an allomorph of the ergative element *-sa*, so that we see *k^ho=sa* instead of the expected **k^ho=wa*.¹⁸ This alternative form also appears variably with demonstratives. The first person pronoun has an alternative stem *kāŋa* with the ergative marker, so that the ergative form is *kāŋa=wa*.¹⁹

Independent possessive pronouns are formed by combining the genitive suffix with the possessive clitics discussed in §3.1.2.

The ablative may stack on top of the locative marker in some cases. To these forms we might also add the simulative marker *=tika~=taka* ‘like’, although this is used with a wider range of elements than nominals.

3.4 Nominal derivation

Nouns may be derived in a number of ways. In many cases nouns appear to have a complex structure (e.g. the word *kāwa* ‘water’ is evidently related to the word *wa* ‘rain’), but cannot be linked to any productive synchronic process. In other cases, however, derivation appears to be somewhat productive.

For example, one common way of forming neologisms (e.g. to refer to new concepts or technologies) is to combine a noun or a verb in infinitive form with a noun. For example, a word for ‘pen’ is *ts^hab-ma-suŋ* (write-INF-wood). A word for ‘school’ is *nuwa-k^him* (book-house).²⁰ The place of the noun in this construction may be replaced by a bound nominalizer *-su*, e.g. *kai-ma-su* (throw.away-INF-NMZ) ‘garbage’. These words are not especially common, however – in everyday speech borrowing appears to be a more typical way of filling lexical gaps.

Agentive deverbal nouns involve a suffix *-kabi*, attached directly to the verb stem, e.g. *bi-kabi* ‘picker, the person who is picking’, derived from the verb *bi-ma* ‘to pick’.

4 Location marking and adpositions

It is not clear whether a separate category of adpositions should be posited in Sampang. Simple expressions of location and direction are typically realised using oblique (locative, comitative, ablative) case markers.

More complex spatial and temporal relations may be expressed using elements which follow the noun they modify. A short (non-exhaustive) list of these items is given (33). These items are often followed by

¹⁸For some speakers, the ergative affix is *-a*.

¹⁹*=ŋa* is usually a focus suffix. It seems possible that this is a calque of the analogous Nepali form *m-ai=le*, which also includes a lexicalised focus affix in its form.

²⁰Both of these concepts are also frequently expressed using Nepali borrowings.

a case marker, with a typical case in a form expressing location (as opposed to goal or source) given in the table.

	Form	Gloss	Usual Case
	fĩ	‘inside’	Loc
	pak ^{ha}	‘outside’	–
	ts ^h o	‘on top’	Loc
	fĩase	‘in front’	Loc
(33)	muse	‘behind’	Loc
	mui	‘under’	Abl
	t ^h am	‘near’	–
	d ^h ĩtsi	‘around’	–
	d ^h ĩma	‘around, near’	–
	lampe	‘towards’	–

When taking a nominal dependent, these elements may or may not follow a genitive case marked form of the noun.

Adposition-like elements borrowed from Nepali are also found in the language. Two particularly common ones are *pĩts^hi* ‘after’ and *lagi* ‘for’.

5 Particles

Like most languages of the region, Sampang has a collection of elements that reflect information-structural properties. These include the contrastive focus marker *-ŋa*, the inclusive focus marker *-sĩ* and the contrastive topic markers *-bo*, *-ne* and *-tsaĩĩ* (where the last is a Nepali borrowing). The exact distinction between these last three markers is not clear and remains a matter for further study – they occur in similar contexts and may even be combined.

- (34) d^hĩaki=pi ti-u-ma p^heri=ŋa waŋ-a t^hĩpa ruk^ha=pi
 basket=LOC put-PST.3O-CONV again=FOC enter-PST up tree=LOC
 ‘He put it in the basket and again he went up in to the tree.’ (Pear Story, rav1, 11/07/25)
- (35) a. fiobma=ne gaĩ gaĩ=pi bĩdzara tal-a
 now-CONTR.TOP₁ village village=LOC market reach-PST
 ‘[But] now markets have reached every village’ (Changes in Village, rav3, 11/07/2025)
- b. tĩĩ fiobma=tsaĩĩ k^hann-i-kĩ tu-i
 but now-CONTR.TOP₂ good-NPST-LNK sit-NPST
 ‘But now it’s good.’ (Changes in Village, rav3, 11/07/2025)
- c. ĩ=sat^hi [...] =bo=tsaĩĩ pai-to pai-to
 1SG.POSS=friend [PN]=CONTR.TOP₃=CONTR.TOP₂ scream-CONV.SIM scream-CONV.SIM
 tuw-a-j-a
 sit-PST-CONT-PST
 ‘As for my friend [name], he was sitting there screaming and screaming.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

A particularly important element is the marker *=sĩ*, which is perhaps best described as an inclusive focus marker, translateable into English as ‘too’ or ‘even’ (I consistently gloss it with the former). When combined with *wh*-words, the latter are treated as indefinite pro-forms which may be translated using e.g. negative polarity items (‘anything’ etc.) or free-relative indefinites (‘whatever’ etc.).

- (36) iskul-a=sĩ taq^ha tuw-a
 school-FV=too far sit-PST
 ‘The school was far too’ (Changes in Village, rav3, 11/07/2025)

- (37) amka=ts^hori tseli jã ts^h-i=d^hã=sã amnum=mi=ŋa g-e
 1PL.EXC.POSS=daughter girl what become-NPST=COND=**too** 2PL.POSS=GEN=FOC say-1PL
 ‘Whatever happens, we will call our daughter yours.’ (Marriage Traditions, rav15, 20/07/2025)

6 Adjectival elements

Sampang has a relatively limited stock of native adjectival forms, supplemented by a wide range of Nepali loans. Even where property concepts are expressed by native terms, these are typically analysable as verbal in nature. Exceptions to this include the words for ‘big’ and ‘small’, as well as colour terms, although the latter are frequently replaced by Nepali borrowings.

6.1 The Attributive Linker

Both verbal property words and ‘true’ adjectives generally appear together with the attributive element *-ka*. In fact, this element is not restricted to property concepts, and also appears with nouns in certain genitive constructions, with embedded clauses (including relative clauses, and various types of complement clauses), and on main (dynamic) verbs, either as part of a periphrastic aspectual formation or sometimes as an unaccompanied main verb. The final syllable of demonstratives might also be plausibly identified with this element.

(38) *Possible Uses for Linker*

a. *‘True’ Adjectives*

saku-**ka** mina
 small-**LNK** person

‘small person’

b. *Property Verbs*

k^hann-i-**ka** k^ha
 be.good-NPST-**LNK** speech

‘good speech’

c. *Nouns*

ts^hΛ sat bΛrsa-**ka** tuw-ã-ka bela
 six seven year-**LNK** sit-1SG-**LNK** time

‘When I was six or seven years old... [lit. of six or seven years]’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

d. *Relative clauses*

ma^hka mina ŋas-Λ-**ka** wadi
 that person fry-NPST.3O-**LNK** egg

‘The egg that that person will fry’

e. *Infinitival complement clauses*

kã k^hai-ma-**ka** jodzΛna tu-i
 1SG GO-INF-**LNK** plan sit-NPST

‘I plan to go’

f. *Periphrastic aspects*

sΛbΛi t^hok-a p^her-a ts^h-a-**ka** tu-i
 all thing-FV change-FV become-PST-**LNK** sit-NPST

‘Everything has changed.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

g. *Unaccompanied main verb*

k^hΛkalama k^him las-a-tsi-ka-**ka**
 after.that house return-PST-NSG-EXC-**LNK**

‘After that, we returned home.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

This marker corresponds to elements that are often described as *nominalisers* in the descriptive and typological literature (e.g. Matisoff 1972, DeLancey 2002, Bickel 1999, Genetti et al. 2008, Genetti 2011). I have avoided this terminology as it seems to me that there is not strong evidence for the nominal status of forms bearing this marker. The distribution of forms bearing *-ka* and the distribution of underived nouns are quite distinct. Rather this linker appears to primarily be used in modification and predication constructions.

6.2 ‘True’ Adjectives

Apart from borrowings, the following words are attested as ‘true’, non-verbal adjectives in Sampang.

(39) ‘True’ adjectives in Sampang

Form	Gloss
ɖʰjappa~ɖʰjappa	‘big’
saku	‘small’
tsuŋa	‘cold’
ʌmbʌʌ(ʌ)	‘white’
mʌkatsu	‘black’
fiʌlʌ	‘red’
mikulʌ	‘green’
bʌbʌri(ma)	‘yellow’

These can be distinguished from verbal property concept words in not inflecting for person/number, tense or other verbal categories. They typically co-occur with the linking morpheme *-ka*, even in predicative position:

- (40) nʌkʌ kʰim ɖʰjappa-**ka** tu-i
 that house big-LNK sit-NPST
 ‘That house is big.’ (Dahl TMA Questionnaire #1)

This stands in contrast to the behaviour of Nepali loanwords, which typically lack the linking morpheme.

- (41) pʌila bʌrsa **tsiso** tuw-a
 last year cold sit-PST
 ‘Last year it [the lake] was cold.’ (Dahl TMA Questionnaire #35)

6.3 Stative Verbs

The vast majority of native terms denoting property concepts can in fact be considered verbal stems. For example, the words denoting *tastes* are verbal in nature, as are words denoting temperature and related concepts, as well as internal states of humans. A selection are given in (42) – they are given in a non-past tense form together with the linker morpheme: this is the usual form elicited when a Nepali or English adjective is translated, and more generally the most common form of these elements.

(42) *Stative Verbs denoting Property Concepts*

Form	Gloss
kʰann-i-kʌ	‘good’
kʰais-i-kʌ	‘bad’
kʰik-i-kʌ	‘bitter’
lim-i-kʌ	‘sweet’
tsur-i-kʌ	‘sour’
sos-i-kʌ	‘spicy’
tʰup-i-kʌ	‘astringent’
fiak-i-kʌ	‘warm’

These may appear in this form before nouns, and also appear in the same form in predicative position, together with a form of the copula *tu-ma*. In this construction, the form of the predicate *does not* agree with the subject, though the form of the copula does.

- (43) k^hann-i-kΛ =ŋa tuw-ã
 good-NPST-LNK=FOC sit-1SG
 ‘I am well.’

This contrasts with periphrastic aspects of dynamic verbs on the one hand (for which see below), and these property concept verbs used as full finite predicates on the other – in both of these cases, we see agreement on the predicate.

- (44) kã k^hann-ã
 1SG good-1SG
 ‘I am well.’
- (45) kã ana=lai t-u-ŋ-dur-u-ŋ-kΛ tu-i
 1SG 2SG=DAT see-PST.3O-1SGS-COMPL-PST.3O-1SGS-LNK sit-NPST[3SG]
 ‘I have already seen you.’

7 Morphology of verbs

In contrast to the relatively simple nominal morphology, Sampang verbal morphology is very complex. A multiactantial agreement system (with both subject agreement and object agreement) interacts with a large array of valency-changing morphs and aspectual elements, among other morphological material. Here and elsewhere, the citation form of the verb is taken to be the infinitive in *-ma*.

Unlike many other Kiranti languages, the Sampang verb is overwhelmingly suffixing.²¹ The sequence of affixes in the finite verbal complex can be summarised as follows:²²

- (46) V₁-(Caus)-(Appl)-(Redup-V₂)-(Ana)-Tense-(Agr)-(Neg)

Infinitives have a stripped down set of possibilities:

- (47) V₁-(Caus)-(Appl)-(Redup-V₂)-Inf

Not shown here are the various positions for morphophonological ‘nasal reduplication’ of first person markers, which may appear in various positions, within the sequence of agreement markers as well as preceding applicative markers.

7.1 Basic Finite Verb Inflection

7.1.1 Tense

Sampang has a two-way tense distinction, between *past* and *non-past* forms. In the absence of other aspectual marking, these may either have a habitual or a perfective reading. These tenses are marked with suffixes *-a* and *-i*, respectively, though morphological considerations discussed above and below may mean that they fail to surface or surface in a modified form.

- (48) *Sampang Tense markers*
- | | Form | Gloss |
|----------|------|-------|
| Past | -a | PST |
| Non-past | -i | NPST |

²¹A reviewer correctly points out that predominantly suffixing languages are not at all unusual among Kiranti languages. Sampang takes this to an unusual extent, however, lacking any prefixes whatsoever except for an extremely restricted negative prefix *man-*, which only occurs with the copular verb *tuma*.

²²Some abbreviations used here: *Caus* = Causative, *Appl* = Applicative, *Agr* = Agreement markers, *Neg* = Negation, *Inf* = Infinitive. *Redup* denotes a reduplicated or metathesised first syllable of the tense/agreement complex (or infinitive marker) following a secondary verb stem. The *Ana* position includes markers of anaphoricity (reflexives, reciprocals) as well as 1→2 markers. The verbal complex may include more than one verb stem (with the second typically serving as a marker of aspect), and this is reflected here.

7.1.2 Agreement in intransitive verbs

Agreement in intransitive verbs is relatively straightforward – the verb stem and tense marker are marked with various suffixes which mark person and number. For singular and plural forms, person and number are essentially fused into a single marker, but for dual forms number is consistently marked with a single marker *-tsi*. In the dual, person is only overtly marked for second person subjects. The relevant endings are shown in (49):

(49) *Subject agreement in intransitive verbs*

	SG	Du	PL
1INC	(N/A)	-tsi	-e
1EXC	-ã	-tsi-ka	-e-ka
2	-na	-tsi-na	-ni
3	-Ø	-tsi	-mi

The first person singular and plural endings are vowel-initial and as such do not co-occur with a tense marker (see §2.5.2), neutralising the distinction between tenses. In the transitive paradigm below, this position may also be filled by other agreeing elements.

Consider the example paradigm of *im-ma* ‘to sleep’ below:

(50) *Conjugation of im-ma*

	PST	NPST
1SG	<i>ims-ã</i>	<i>ims-ã</i>
2SG	<i>ims-a-na</i>	<i>ims-i-na</i>
3SG	<i>ims-a</i>	<i>ims-i</i>
1DU.INC	<i>ims-a-tsi</i>	<i>ims-i-tsi</i>
1DU.EXC	<i>ims-a-tsi-ka</i>	<i>ims-i-tsi-ka</i>
2DU	<i>ims-a-tsi-na</i>	<i>ims-i-tsi-na</i>
1PL.INC	<i>ims-e</i>	<i>ims-e</i>
1PL.EXC	<i>ims-e-ka</i>	<i>ims-e-ka</i>
2PL	<i>ims-a-ni</i>	<i>ims-i-ni</i>
3PL	<i>ims-a-mi</i>	<i>ims-i-mi</i>

The analysis in this sketch was developed independently of Huysmans (2011), and deviates from it in a number of respects. Some of the differences are empirical, and possibly attributable to poorly-understood variation in the system, which remains a topic for further research.

There are also analytical differences, however. In the intransitive paradigm, this is most notable in the treatment of the non-past suffix *-i*. Huysmans explicitly rejects the analysis of this marker as an independent non-past suffix, and proposes that the /i/ in non-past forms is part of the person suffix. The grounds on which he does so, however, are largely comparative, relating to the absence of this suffix in other Kiranti languages. This results in a substantial loss of synchronic generalisation in the paradigm, and as such I do not adopt his analysis.

7.1.3 Agreement in transitive verbs

The agreement pattern in transitive verbs is substantially more complicated than the agreement pattern in intransitive verbs. Typically, we see agreement with both subject and object (in particular if there is an animate object). The morphological principles governing the precise exponence of subject and object markers are quite complex, and subject to a good deal of optional variation. The basic exponents of subject and object arguments are shown in (51)–(53). Ellipses represent positions occupied by material associated with other arguments. These are the forms that co-occur with consonant-final stems. As discussed in §2.5, there may be additional morphophonological complications with V-V stems.

(51) *Subject markers in transitive verbs*

	Sg	Du	Pl
1INC	(N/A)	---tsu	-m
1EXC	-ŋ	---tsu-ka	-m---ka
2	---na	---tsu---na	---num
3	-Ø	---tsu	---mi

The form of the object marker depends partially on the tense of the verb. The relevant forms are shown below:

(52) *Object markers in past tense transitive verbs*

	Sg	Du	Pl
1INC	(N/A)	-tsi	-e
1EXC	-ã	---tsi-ka	-e---ka
2	---na	---tsi---na	---ni
3	-u	-u---tsi	

(53) *Object markers in non-past transitive verbs*

	Sg	Du	Pl
1INC	(N/A)	-e---tsi	-e
1EXC	-e	-e---tsi-ka	-e---ka
2	---na	-tsi---na	-ni
3	-Λ	-Λ---tsi	

Typically, object markers precede subject markers. The markers *-ka* (1st person exclusive) and *-na* (2nd person nonplural), however, which may mark either subject or object, always follow other morphological material (with the exception of negation, the ‘linker’ *-ka* and the converbial markers such as *-ma*). When they co-occur, they respect the generalisation that object markers precede subject markers.

There are a number of complications to this pattern. The three most important are as follows:

1. Forms with first person subjects and second person objects have special forms which involve a suffix *-n-* surfacing before other morphological material, including the tense marker.²³ This triggers the preconsonantal form of the verb stem. The first person marker then does not surface, nor does the unmarked second person suffix *-na*. Alternatively, the third person object forms may be used in this context.
2. Third person object markers are typically unrealised before the dual subject marker *-tsu* and the second person plural subject marker *-num*.
3. No more than one marker of non-singular number may appear in a given form. A general rule of thumb is that markers are retained following the person hierarchy 1 > 2 > 3, with number markers associated with the person higher on the hierarchy retained. An apparent exception to this is the 1st person plural object marker *-e*, which under certain circumstances may appear alongside 2nd and 3rd person nonsingular markers. However, it should be noted that this form is *not* exclusively a non-singular marker, also appearing as a singular form in non-past transitive verbs.

This is in addition to the morphophonological alternations detailed in §2.5.2.

There is also a great deal of optional variation in the system, some of which is detailed in the following discussion.

A few differences from the analysis of Huysmans (2011) will be worth highlighting here. Huysmans analyses the dual subject markers as bearing a third person object marker *-u* attached to a non-singular marker *-tsi*. This marker does indeed only occur with third person, but I do not adopt Huysmans’ analysis, for a few reasons. Firstly, the distribution of this marker is different to the 3rd person object marker elsewhere: the 3rd person object marker elsewhere varies for tense, with, but the dual subject marker is invariant for tense. Secondly, as may be observed, the same marker appears in the *possessive* paradigm (24), where no 3rd person object is present.

²³This form appears in the same position as the reflexive suffix *-n-*, and we might wonder if there is a connection here.

Similar considerations apply to the 2pl subject marker, which Huysmans analyses as constituting a combination of a neutral 2pl marker *-ini* and a 1st/2nd plural agent marker *-m*. This may be diachronically justified, but synchronically also runs into the problem that the form *-num* is also found in the possessive paradigm (24), even though the 1st person inclusive forms in this paradigm lack *-m*.²⁴

Both these suffixes co-occur with what I analyse as a morphophonological alternant of the non-past tense marker, which is usually (though not exceptionlessly) /u/ before these forms rather than /i/. Huysmans, by contrast, also analyses this form as a 3rd person object morpheme. This is *prima facie* not a straightforward analysis, again due to the failure of tense-induced allomorphy in the putative object morph – the environments in which it occurs are precisely the inverse of where the 3rd person object marker *-u* occurs in other forms. That is to say, appears exclusively in non-past forms and fails to appear in past tense forms. A morphophonological analysis provides a more straightforward account of the facts.

Let us go through an example paradigm of the verb *jam-ma* ‘to hit, to beat’. The paradigm will be presented in 9 parts, each representing a particular number combination. Optional variants and morphophonological alternations will be noted where relevant. The forms in the tables are those with the simplest exponence given the affixes and principles outlined above, but should not necessarily be taken to be the most frequent forms. We will begin with singular subject/singular object (SG→SG forms).

(54) Conjugation of SG→SG forms of *jam-ma* ‘to beat’ (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1	2	3
1	(Refl) <i>jam-n-a</i>	<i>japs-u-ŋ</i>	
2	<i>japs-ā-na</i>	(Refl) <i>japs-u-na</i>	
3	<i>japs-ā</i>	<i>japs-a-na</i>	<i>japs-u</i>

(55) Conjugation of SG→SG forms of *jam-ma* ‘to beat’ (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1	2	3
1	(Refl) <i>jam-n-i</i>	<i>japs-ā</i>	
2	<i>japs-e-na</i>	(Refl) <i>japs-a-na</i>	
3	<i>japs-e</i>	<i>japs-i-na</i>	<i>japs-a</i>

It will be observed that there is a stem alternation here between the prevocalic form *japs-* and the preconsonantal form *jam-* (see discussion in §2.5.1), the latter of which occurs as detailed above before the portmanteau 1→2 suffix *-n-*, which appears immediately between the stem and tense-marker. Because the first and third person object markers are vowel-initial, they trigger deletion of the tense-marker.²⁵ Following the third person non-past object marker *-a*, the 1st person subject suffix *-ŋ* is realised as vowel nasalisation. This is also optionally the case in the past tense forms following *-u*. The 1→2 forms may optionally be realised using the 1→3 forms (so that e.g. we see *japs-u-ŋ* instead of *jam-n-a*). Here and elsewhere, cells marked ‘(Refl)’ only make use of a special reflexive form which behaves in part like the intransitive paradigm (see §7.1.4 for more details on these forms). Now let us consider forms with dual objects (SG→DU).

(56) Conjugation of SG→DU forms of *jam-ma* ‘to beat’ (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1	(Refl) <i>jam-n-a-tsi</i>	(Refl) <i>japs-u-ŋ-tsu-ŋ</i>		
2	(Refl) <i>japs-a-tsi-ka-na</i>	(Refl) <i>japs-u-tsi-na</i>		
3	<i>japs-a-tsi</i>	<i>japs-a-tsi-ka</i>	<i>japs-a-tsi-na</i>	<i>japs-u-tsi</i>

(57) Conjugation of SG→DU forms of *jam-ma* ‘to beat’ (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1	(Refl) <i>jam-n-i-tsi</i>	(Refl) <i>japs-ā-tsu-ŋ</i>		
2	(Refl) <i>japs-e-tsi-ka-na</i>	(Refl) <i>japs-a-tsi-na</i>		
3	<i>japs-e-tsi</i>	<i>japs-e-tsi-ka</i>	<i>japs-i-tsi-na</i>	<i>japs-a-tsi</i>

²⁴The 1st person exclusive forms *do* have an /m/ in their form but not in the relevant position, instead preceding the number marker. In fact 3rd person forms also have an /m/ in this position, making its analysis as a 1st/2nd person marker unviable.

²⁵An alternative analysis might take the 1st and 3rd person object markers to be portmanteau morphs with the tense markers. For the first person, I do not assume this because the relevant forms *-ā* and *-e* appear as markers indifferent to tense elsewhere in the Sampang morphological system – most notably, in the intransitive paradigm, as 1st person singular and 1st person plural markers, respectively. If we do not analyse 1st person elements as portmanteau morphs, then analysing third person elements as such becomes somewhat less attractive too, although such an analysis is not ruled out.

The 1→3 forms here show ‘nasal reduplication’ (see §2.5.2) – the first person subject affix appears in two positions, after the person marker and after the number marker (in the non-past forms, the former is realised as nasalisation). There is a morphophonological rule altering the form of the number marker *-tsi* to *-tsu* in these forms. Optionally, the number marker may be omitted in the 2/3→3 forms. The realisation of the 1st person morph *-e* is optional in the non-past tense, so that we may also see *japs-i-tsi*.

(58) Conjugation of SG→PL forms of jam-ma ‘to beat’ (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-a-ni	japs-u-η-tsu-η
2	(Refl)	japs-e-ka-na	(Refl)	japs-u-tsi-na
3	japs-e	japs-e-ka	japs-a-ni	japs-u-tsi

(59) Conjugation of SG→PL forms of jam-ma ‘to beat’ (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-i-ni	japs-ā-tsu-η
2	(Refl)	japs-e-ka-na	(Refl)	japs-λ-tsi-na
3	japs-e	japs-e-ka	japs-i-ni	japs-λ-tsi

Here the tense distinction with first person objects is neutralised due to the vowel-initial suffix *-e*. Again, the number marker *-tsi* is omissible in the 2/3→3 forms. Now let us turn to forms with dual subjects, first with singular objects.

(60) Conjugation of DU→SG forms of jam-ma ‘to beat’ (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-a-tsu
1exc	(Refl)	jam-n-a	japs-a-tsu-ka
2	japs-ā-tsu-na	(Refl)	japs-a-tsu-na
3	japs-ā-tsu-η	japs-a-na	japs-a-tsu

(61) Conjugation of DU→SG forms of jam-ma ‘to beat’ (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-u-tsu
1exc	(Refl)	jam-n-i	japs-u-tsu-ka
2	japs-e-tsi-na	(Refl)	japs-u-tsu-na
3	japs-e-tsi	japs-i-na	japs-u-tsu

Here in the 3→1 form we see nasal reduplication again. We also see the dual subject affix *-tsu* being realised as *-tsi* after the 1st person object marker *-e* in the non-past forms. Before the dual subject marker *-tsu*, the non-past tense marker *-i* is realised as *-u* (see §2.5.2). This is not true in all verbs, however – for example, V-V stems with a prevocalic final /i/ block this, so that we see *m-i-tsu* (DO-NPST-DU.SUBJ) from *mo-ma* ‘to do’. As noted above, third person object markers are not found with dual subjects. Dual number also fails to be marked in third person subjects in the 2→3 forms here. 1→2 forms do not show distinctions for subject number, although they may be replaced with 1→3 forms, which do. Now let us consider DU→DU forms.

(62) Conjugation of DU→DU forms of jam-ma ‘to beat’ (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-a-tsu
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-a-tsi	japs-a-tsu-ka
2	(Refl)	japs-a-tsi-ka-na	(Refl)	japs-a-tsu-na
3	japs-a-tsi	japs-a-tsi-ka	japs-a-tsi-na	japs-a-tsu

(63) Conjugation of DU→DU forms of jam-ma ‘to beat’ (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-u-tsu
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-i-tsi	japs-u-tsu-ka
2	(Refl)	japs-e-tsi-ka-na	(Refl)	japs-u-tsu-na
3	japs-e-tsi	japs-e-tsi-ka	japs-i-tsi-na	japs-u-tsu

Here in the 2/3→1 forms, the dual subject marker is deleted (in accordance with principle 3 above), and similarly in the 3→2 forms. Other considerations are similar to the singular forms above, with few additional complications. The DU→PL forms are more complicated, however.

(64) Conjugation of DU→PL forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-a-tsu
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-a-ni	japs-a-tsu-ka
2	(Refl)	japs-e-ka-na	(Refl)	japs-a-tsu-na
3	japs-e	japs-e-ka	japs-a-ni	japs-a-tsu

(65) Conjugation of DU→PL forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-u-tsu
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-i-ni	japs-u-tsu-ka
2	(Refl)	japs-e-tsi-ka-na	(Refl)	japs-u-tsu-na
3	japs-e-tsi	japs-e-tsi-ka	japs-i-ni	japs-u-tsu

The first person object forms here seem to be quite variable, in particular, concerning whether the forms in question have a number marker *-tsi*. Consultants have offered both non-past forms without the number marker *-tsi* and past forms with it. I suggest that this variability is related to the ambiguity of the 1st person marker *-e*, which may be a 1st person plural object marker, but may also be a general 1st person marker, also appearing in singular forms. When combined with other marked non-singular forms, I assume, this means it may or may not trigger deletion of the number marker (in accordance with principle 3 above). If the number marker is not deleted, it undergoes 'brightening' from *-tsu* to *-tsi*, as discussed above. I have shown the past forms without the number marker and the present forms with it, observing that those forms seem to be more common in their respective tenses. This may be because the use of *-e* as an element without number specification is more straightforwardly visible in the non-past tense. It should however be emphasised that both forms have been elicited in both tenses, however. Now let us turn to the forms with plural subjects, starting with PL→SG forms.

(66) Conjugation of PL→SG forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-u-m
1exc	(Refl)	jam-n-a	japs-u-m-ka
2	japs-ã-num	(Refl)	japs-a-num
3	japs-ã-mu-ŋ	japs-a-mi-na	japs-u-mi

(67) Conjugation of PL→SG forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-a-m
1exc	(Refl)	jam-n-i	japs-a-m-ka
2	japs-e-num	(Refl)	japs-u-num
3	japs-e-mi	japs-i-mi-na	japs-a-mi

Here again we see nasal reduplication in the 3→1 forms. We see no third person object marker before the 2nd person plural marker. The 1st person past plural form optionally surfaces with neither subject nor object marker as *japs-a*. 3rd person subject forms, especially in combination with 3rd person objects, are often realised using a suffix *-tsi* instead of *-mi* (also with dual and plural objects).

(68) Conjugation of PL→DU forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-u-m
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-a-tsi	japs-u-m-ka
2	(Refl)	japs-ã-nuŋ-ka	(Refl)	japs-a-num
3	japs-a-tsi	japs-a-tsi-ka	japs-a-tsi-na	japs-u-mi

(69) Conjugation of PL→DU forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs- <i>Λ</i> -m
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-i-tsi	japs- <i>Λ</i> -m-ka
2	(Refl)	japs-e-nuŋ-ka	(Refl)	japs-u-num
3	japs-e-tsi	japs-e-tsi-ka	japs-i-tsi-na	japs- <i>Λ</i> -mi

Here again we have a great deal of optional variation where the 1st person objects are involved – in both tenses forms such as *japs-e-mi*, with the third person plural marker retained, are not uncommon. Note the number neutralisation of the 1st person object forms with the second person subject – all forms are identical to the form with the singular object.

(70) Conjugation of PL→PL forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs-u-m
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-a-ni	japs-u-m-ka
2	(Refl)	japs- <i>Λ</i> -nuŋ-ka	(Refl)	japs-a-num
3	japs-e	japs-e-ka	japs-a-ni	japs-u-mi

(71) Conjugation of PL→PL forms of jam-ma 'to beat' (non-past tense)

↓SUBJ OBJ→	1inc	1exc	2	3
1inc	(Refl)	(Refl)	(Refl)	japs- <i>Λ</i> -m
1exc	(Refl)	(Refl)	jam-n-i-ni	japs- <i>Λ</i> -m-ka
2	(Refl)	japs-e-nuŋ-ka	(Refl)	japs-u-num
3	japs-e-mi	japs-e-mi-ka	japs-i-ni	japs- <i>Λ</i> -mi

Again in these forms there is a great deal of variation in the 3→1 forms, along similar lines to the dual subject examples discussed above. Again the forms given here seem to be more common in their respective tenses, presumably for reasons similar to those discussed above for the dual forms, but both sets of forms have been found in both tenses. Here again we see number neutralisation with 2nd person subjects.

7.1.4 Anaphoric forms

Sampang has a special set of agreeing forms for utterances with anaphoric meaning, with special endings for reflexives and reciprocals. The forms for reflexives are shown in (72), where the ellipsis is the position of the tense marker.

(72) Agreement with reflexive predicates

	Sg	Du	Pl
1INC	(N/A)	-n-...-tsi	-n-e
1EXC	-n- <i>Λ</i> -tsu-ŋ	-n-...-tsi-ka	-n-e-ka
2	-n-...-tsi-na	-n-...-tsi-na	-n-...-ni
3	-n-...-tsi	-n-...-tsi	-n-...-mi

These forms are made up of multiple parts, beginning with an anaphoric marker *-n-* (reflexive) or *-m^Λ-* (reciprocal).²⁶ Before front vowels, such as the present tense marker *-i* or the first person plural marker *-e*, the vowel is deleted. Otherwise the suffixal vowel is deleted.²⁷ These elements precede tense-markers (and consequently trigger a pre-consonantal form of the verb). This is coupled with intransitive inflectional endings, with the addition in singular forms of a spurious non-singular marker *-tsi* (with the result that singular and dual are not contrasted with 2nd and 3rd persons). Nasal copying also applies in the first person singular. The anaphoric forms of *to-ma* 'to see' are given in (73, 74):

²⁶Some speakers appear to have *-mi-* as their reciprocal marker.

²⁷For speakers with *-mi-*, the suffixal vowel is not deleted and we see gliding of the reciprocal suffix to *-mj-*

(73) *Reflexive forms of to-ma 'to see'*

	PST	NPST
1SG	<i>to-n-ã-tsu-ŋ</i>	<i>to-n-ã-tsu-ŋ</i>
2SG	<i>to-n-a-tsi-na</i>	<i>to-n-i-tsi-na</i>
3SG	<i>to-n-a-tsi</i>	<i>to-n-i-tsi</i>
1DU.INC	<i>to-n-a-tsi</i>	<i>to-n-i-tsi</i>
1DU.EXC	<i>to-n-a-tsi-ka</i>	<i>to-n-i-tsi-ka</i>
2DU	<i>to-n-a-tsi-na</i>	<i>to-n-i-tsi-na</i>
1PL.INC	<i>to-n-e</i>	<i>to-n-e</i>
1PL.EXC	<i>to-n-e-ka</i>	<i>to-n-e-ka</i>
2PL	<i>to-n-a-ni</i>	<i>to-n-i-ni</i>
3PL	<i>to-n-a-mi</i>	<i>to-n-e-mi</i>

(74) *Reciprocal forms of to-ma 'to see'*

	PST	NPST
1DU.INC	<i>to-m-ã-tsi</i>	<i>to-m-i-tsi</i>
1DU.EXC	<i>to-m-ã-tsi-ka</i>	<i>to-m-i-tsi-ka</i>
2DU	<i>to-m-ã-tsi-na</i>	<i>to-m-i-tsi-na</i>
1PL.INC	<i>to-m-e</i>	<i>to-m-e</i>
1PL.EXC	<i>to-m-e-ka</i>	<i>to-m-e-ka</i>
2PL	<i>to-m-ã-ni</i>	<i>to-m-i-ni</i>
3PL	<i>to-m-ã-mi</i>	<i>to-m-i-mi</i>

One of my consultants collapses the reflexive/reciprocal distinction in some plural forms, consistently using *-mi-* for both.

7.1.5 *Mood*

As well as the indicative forms discussed so far Sampang displays a number of marked modal forms, including imperatives and forms which I label optatives.

Imperatives Imperatives in Sampang are generally similar in form to simple past tense verbs, taking a suffix *-a* in intransitives and varying for object agreement in transitives. They are inflected for object agreement where transitive, and also display number agreement for subjects (using the second person forms, but omitting the suffix *-na*). Since 2nd person plural forms are used as honorifics, plural inflection can also be used to create a polite imperative.

(75) *Imperative Forms*a. *Familiar Imperative*

tso
eat.IMP[SG]
'Eat!'

b. *Polite/plural Imperative*

ts-a-num
eat-IMP-2PLS
'[Please] eat!'

An interesting contrast between imperatives and past tense verbs is that the former readily allow non-singular object markers to co-occur with non-singular subject markers. Note also that the 2pl marker appears *after* the clusivity marker in these forms.

(76) *Object agreement in imperatives*

kaeka=lai p-e-ka-num
 1PL.IMP=DAT give-1PLO(IMP)-EXC-2PLS

‘Give [the bride] to us!’ (Marriage Traditions, rav15, 20/07/25)

Optatives A range of forms with optative-like modality (expressing the wishes of the speaker) can be formed with a modal suffix attached to bases of varying sizes. A third person optative may make use of a suffix *-ne* (attached to a stem), a 1st person cohortative *-ke* (attached to non-past forms), and a 2nd person exhortative *-je* (attached to an imperative).

(77) *3rd person optative*

um=k^hai-ma l-i-d^hĩ k^hai-ne
 3SG.POSS=go-INF want-NPST-COND go-OPT

‘If he wants to go let him go!’

(78) *1st person cohortative*

duw-Λ-m-ke
 drink-3O.NPST-1PLS-COHORT

‘Let’s drink!’

(79) *2nd person exhortative*

duw-a-num-je
 drink-IMP-2PLS-EXH

‘Please drink!’

7.1.6 *Negation*

Negation is typically marked with a suffix *-na/-nĩ* following tense and agreement markers.²⁸ Unlike related languages such as Kulung and Nachiring, this is true of both non-past and past forms.²⁹

(80) *Negation marking*

fiallo-sĩ matt-ĩ-s-ĩ-nĩ
 when-too forget₁-NPST.3O.1SGS-forget₂-NPST.3O.1SGS-NEG

‘I will never forget it.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

kĩ im-ma dur-u-ŋ-nĩ
 1SG sleep-INF can-PST.1SG-NEG

‘I couldn’t sleep.’

Following the second person agreement markers *-na*, it takes on an allomorph *-na*. The existential/attributive copula and auxiliary *tu-ma* is an exception to this pattern, instead taking a prefix *man-*.

(81) *Negation of copula*

a. kĩ mΛpi **man**-tuw-ĩ
 1SG there NEG-sit-1SG
 ‘I’m not there.’

b. k^ho-sa ts^hab-u-dur-u-ka **man**-tu-d^hĩ ana ts^hab-u
 3SG-ERG write-PST.3O-finish-PST.3O-LNK NEG-sit-COND 2SG write-IMP.3O
 ‘If he hasn’t finished writing it, you write it.’

²⁸The nasalisation here is variable and probably arises as a consequence of the nasal initial consonant.

²⁹Thanks to a reviewer for pointing out the relevance of this point.

7.2 Functional verbs

7.2.1 Copulas

Sampang has three main types of copular expression, of which two are fully verbal, while one involves a series of indeclinable particles. By copular expression, I mean any lexical item creating a structure which licenses a non-verbal expression to provide the core content of the predicate of a clause.

Existential/attributive copula This copula is identical in form to the verb ‘to sit’ *tu-ma*, and is glossed as such here. It is used to state that its subject exists (possibly in a particular place) or has a particular (adjectival) attribute.

(82) *Copula usage*

- a. *kã mɔpi man-tuw-ã*
 1SG there NEG-sit-1SG
 ‘I’m not there.’
- b. *kʰo kã-bʰanda ɔlo tu-i*
 3SG 1SG-COMP tall sit-NPST
 ‘He is taller than me’

Possessive forms are also typically formed with this copula, together with a comitative-marked possessor:

(83) *Possessive usage of copula*

- kã=lo kɔlam tu-i*
 1SG=COM pen sit-NPST
 ‘I have a pen.’

It is also used as an auxiliary together with a participle to form perfect, future and conditional forms.

Change of state copula This copula (*tsʰu-ma*) is used to imply that its subject has undergone a change of state. It will be glossed consistently as ‘become’, reflecting this usage.

- (84) *kepilasgadhɪ tsʰ-a-kɔ tu-i*
 Kepilasgadhi become-PST-LNK sit-NPST
 ‘[The name of the municipality] has become Kepilasgadhi’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

It can also be used to indicate the occurrence of an event or events:

(85) *Copula indicating occurrence*

- jã jã tsʰ-a*
 what what become-PST
 ‘What happened?’

It is also used as a light verb in intransitive noun-verb compounds, including verbal elements borrowed from Nepali:

(86) *Light verb usage of copula*

- nam dub-a tsʰ-a*
 sun sink-FV become-PST
 ‘The sun set.’

In some cases, it may be used to express future or counterfactual existence or attributes (this usage perhaps influenced by the use of Nepali translation equivalents like *huncha*).

(87) *Attributive usage of ts^hu-ma*

kã at^hepa ims-ã-kΛ=d^hã kã t^hak-a ts^h-ã-nã-kΛ
 1SG yesterday sleep-1SG-LNK=COND 1SG tire-FV **become**-1SG-NEG-LNK

‘If I had slept yesterday I wouldn’t be tired.’

It is also used as a modal with permissive or deontic reading (‘must, may’):

(88) *Modal usage of copula*a. *Deontic usage*

pãila lunṭsa b^hΛ-ma ts^h-i
 first millet boil-INF **become**-NPST

‘First you have to boil millet.’ (Beer Making 08/09/21)

b. *Permissive usage*

asa t-i-mi=d^hã=sã ts^h-i
 who come-NPST-3PL=COND=too **become**-NPST

‘Anyone can come.’

Essential copula This copula appears in identificational (specifying the identity of a particular entity), classificatory (stating a class that the subject belongs to) and equative (stating that two entities are the same) statements between noun-phrases. Unlike the other two forms just discussed, which are fully conjugated verbs, the essential copula (cop) is an indeclinable particle which does not display verbal inflection. The form of the particle in question is, however, sensitive to the polarity and illocutionary force of the sentence – in positive declaratives, for example, it takes the form *fi*o or *fi*Λ. Given the fact that (as a reviewer points out) positive copulas of this type are generally absent in the Kiranti languages, it seems plausible that this form is borrowed from the homophonous and broadly synonymous Nepali word *ho*. Unlike the Nepali form, however, the Sampang form does not inflect for number/gender/tense.

(89) *Positive declarative copula*

nΛkΛ pi fi
 this cow **COP**

‘This is a cow.’

In interrogatives,, we see another form *le*. This is likely derived from the conjunction *le* ‘or’, but is not exclusively used for alternative questions.³⁰

(90) *Interrogative copula*

nΛkΛ jã le
 that what **COP.INT**

‘What is this?’

In *negative* declaratives we see yet another form *manã*.

(91) k^ho daktΛra manã
 3SG doctor **NEG.COP**
 ‘S/he is not a doctor.’

In embedded contexts, the meaning of the essential copula may be expressed using the other copular forms listed here.

³⁰A reviewer asks if this could be a general content question marker, but I do not observe it in non-copular non-polar questions.

7.2.2 Participial tenses and aspects

Forms which we might label participles, and which correspond to Nepali participles in usage (see also §7.4.3), are formed by combining *either* an inflected verb form or an infinitive with the ‘linking’ suffix *-ka*. These may be combined with an existential copula to create special aspectual and modal forms.

Perfect Forms Perfect forms are created by combining a participle formed from the past tense verb stem, together with some tense of the existential copula *tuma*.³¹

- (92) *kepilasgaḏ^{hi} ts^h-a-ka tu-i*
 Kepilasgadhi become-PST-LNK sit-NPST
 ‘[The name of the municipality] has become Kepilasgadhi’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

Note that perfective periphrastic forms (unlike imperfective and irrealis forms, as we will see) do not involve agreement on their auxiliary, though we do see full agreement *within* the participial element.

- (93) *matto bela=pi d^hami=wa um=sir-a ts^ho=pi ti-u-ka maka madzur-a*
 such time=LOC shaman=ERG 3SG-head-FC top=LOC wear-PST.3O-LNK that peacock-FV
kae-ka=tsahĩ titepati-mi banmara-mi mu-ŋ-ka-ma ti-ŋ-ka-ka
 1PL.EXC=CONTR.TOP artemesia-GEN eupatorium-GEN make-1PLS-EXC-CONV wear-1PLS-EXC-LNK
tuw-a
sit-PST[3SG]
 ‘We made the peacock crown that a shaman would wear on his head at that time out of artemesia and eupatorium, then wore it’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

Imperfective Forms Imperfective forms combine a inflected form, typically with an explicit imperfective aspect marker, with the linking suffix *-ka* and an existential copula as an auxiliary. The tense is marked both on the ‘participial’ element and on the auxiliary. These likewise tend not to display person agreement on the auxiliary.

- (94) *kã ims-ã-j-ã-ka tu-i*
 1SG sleep-1SG-CONT-1SG-LNK sit-NPST[3SG]
 ‘I am sleeping.’

Irrealis Forms Irrealis forms (future, conditional) typically combine a simple non-past form with the linking suffix *-ka* and an existential copula. Unlike the other participial forms discussed here, these *do* display obligatory agreement on the auxiliary.

- (95) *kã sjelama sjau ts-ã-ka tuw-ã*
 1SG tomorrow apple eat-NPST.3O.1SGS-LNK sit-1SG
 ‘I will eat an apple tomorrow.’

7.3 Complex predicates

Sampang (like most other Kiranti languages) has a number of forms which display multiple verbal elements within a single word. The verbal elements in question can broadly be divided into two classes: those which change the argument structure of a verb (namely causatives and applicatives) and those which do not. These classes can also be picked out morphologically – there are reduplication/metathesis processes which do not appear in causatives or applicatives but do appear in other complex verbal forms.

³¹ As a reviewer points out, this comparable to Nepali constructions in *-eko* + existential/attributive copula *cha*. It is not implausible that the Sampang construction might be present due to influence by its Nepali counterpart.

7.3.1 Causatives

Synthetic causatives may be formed with a suffix *-mj-~me-*, attached directly to the uninflected verb stem. The form *-mj-* is used prevocally and *-me-* preconsonantly. The resulting form takes the usual transitive inflectional endings agreeing along the lines of transitive verbs – see §8.2.2 for more discussion.

- (96) Rame=wa kã=lai Sjame=lo tɔi-mj-ã
 Rame=ERG 1SG=DAT Shyame=COM ask-CAUS-1SGO.PST
 ‘Rame made me ask Shyame.’

Certain causatives, especially those which belong to typical causative-inchoative pairs crosslinguistically, may have alternating argument structure without additional morphology. In this case, the causative counterpart taking transitive inflection and the inchoative taking intransitive inflection.

- (97) *Zero-derived causatives*
 a. *Inchoative*
 kãwa tʰok-a
 water spill-PST
 ‘The water spilt’
 b. *Causative*
 kã kãwa tʰok-u-ŋ
 1SG water spill-PST.3O-1SGS
 ‘I spilt the water’

Sampang shows some traces of the historic Kiranti causativisation process involving a suffix *-s* on the stem (see e.g. Jacques 2017 and references therein). This can be seen e.g. in the contrast between non-alternating *nam-* ‘to smell (vi.)’ and alternating *nam- ~ naps-* ‘to smell (vt.)’.

7.3.2 Applicatives

A benefactive applicative may be formed using the suffix *-pi/pj-*, presumably derived from the verb *pima* ‘to give’. This licenses an additional object argument, reflected in the verbal agreement.

- (98) mɔkɔ keʈa um=pa=wa tetɔŋkɔ pɔisa ɸɔ-pj-u-ma keʈi=lai upɔhar-a
 that boy 3SG.POSS=father=ERG last.year money send-APPL-PST.3O-CONV girl=DAT present-FV
 kʰe-pj-u
 buy-APPL-PST.3O
 ‘When his father sent him the money last year, that boy bought a present for the girl.’ (Dahl tense questionnaire #102)

As this example shows, unlike aspectual suffixes, there is no copy of the first syllable of the tense/agreement complex appearing before the applicative suffixes. However, a nasal reduplication process in first person forms *does* occur.

- (99) kã um-mi kam-a mu-ŋ-pi-ŋ-dur-u-ŋ
 1SG 3SG.POSS-GEN WORK-FV do-1SGS-APPL-1SGS-COMPL-PST.3O-1SGS
 ‘I already did his work for him.’

Kiranti languages also had a historic applicative suffix *-t*. This is detectable in Sampang in pairs such as *pat~pai-* ‘scream, yell’ (← Proto-Kiranti *brat-, following Jacques 2017) and *pai-* ‘shout at, scold’ (← *brat-t-: the change /tt/ → /j/ at the end of verb stems is a regular one.) We also see traces of this affix in the behaviour of motion verbs, discussed in §9.

7.3.3 Compound verbs

Certain verbs in Sampang appear to be formed of more than one inflected stem. A frequent example is the verb *mai-ma-so-ma* ‘to forget’. These forms make use of two verbal stems, the second of which is fully marked for tense and agreement. The first stem bears a copy of the *first syllable* (modulo morphophonological processes) of the inflections of the second (typically functional/aspectual) stem, as discussed in §2.5.

- (100) *fiallo* = *sã matt-ã-s-ã-nã*
 when=too forget₁-NPST.3O.1SGS-**forget**₂-NPST.3O.1SGS-NEG
 ‘I will never forget it’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

A special case of this type is a form which means ‘arrive’, and involves reduplication of the stem of *ta-ma* ‘to come’.

- (101) *ese=ŋa t-a-t-a raits^ha*
 today=FOC **come**-PST-**come**-PST MIR
 ‘[It turns out that] he arrived today’ (Dahl TMA Questionnaire #135)

Complex forms of this type may be lexicalised, as in the preceding examples, but may be used productively to express various aspectual distinctions. The more common aspectual forms are discussed below:

Completive The completive form makes use of the verb *dur-ma*, which may be used as an independent predicate meaning ‘finish’. It expresses the idea that an event has already been completed as of the reference time, and corresponds roughly to Nepali forms in *-i-sak-nu*. Appropriate English translations may include ‘have already V-ed’ or ‘have finished V-ing’.

- (102) *ŋapi ims-a-kA mina fiobela k^hat-a-**dur**-a*
 here sleep-PST-LNK person now go-PST-**COMPL**-PST
 ‘The person who was sleeping here has already gone.’

The completive aspectual auxiliary may be combined with a negator and the progressive aspect to convey the meaning ‘have not yet V-ed’.

- (103) *kã b^hus-ã-**dur**-ã-ñã-nã*
 1SG run-1SG-**COMPL**-1SG-PROG-NEG
 ‘I haven’t run yet.’

Durative The durative form makes use of the stem *ts-* and corresponds to the Nepali forms in *-i-raha-nu*. These forms may be approximately translated into English as ‘keep V-ing’, ‘always V-s’.

- (104) *ts^hA sat barsA-kA tuw-ã-kA bela d^hami ts^hu-ma-kA itta k^hela kaeka lo=sã*
 six seven year-LNK sit-1SG-LNK time shaman become-INF-LNK one game 1PL.EXC when=too
 wal-e-**ts**-e-ka
 play-1PL-**DUR**-1PL-EXC
 ‘When I was six or seven years old, we’d always play a game of being shamans.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

Stative Continuous This aspect corresponds to the use of the English progressive with stative verbs, or the *-i-rah-eko* forms in Nepali. It involves the stem *j-*.

- (105) *ã=sat^hi [...] =bo=tsahĩ pai-to pai-to tuw-a-j-a*
 1SG.POSS=friend [PN]=TOP=TOP scream-CONV.SIM scream-CONV.SIM sit-PST-**CONT**-PST
 ‘As for my friend [name], he was sitting there screaming and screaming.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

Progressive An aspectual form which behaves slightly differently to the others listed here is the *progressive*, which involves an affix *-fiĩ*.³² Rather than reduplicating the first syllable of the tense/agreement sequence, the progressive auxiliary metathesises with it, so that always appears after the first syllable of this sequence.

(106) *Selected progressive forms of b^{fi}ul-ma ‘to run’*

- a. b^{fi}us-i-fiĩ
run-NPST-PROG
(3rd person singular subject)
- b. b^{fi}us-ĩ-fiĩ
run-1SG-PROG
(1st person singular subject)
- c. b^{fi}us-i-fiĩ-tsi
run-NPST-PROG-DU
(1st inclusive/3rd person dual subject)
- d. b^{fi}us-i-fiĩ-na
run-NPST-PROG-2
(2nd person singular subject)
- e. b^{fi}us-i-fiĩ-ni
run-NPST-PROG-2PL
(2nd person plural subject)
- f. b^{fi}us-e-fiĩ
run-1PL-PROG
(1st person inclusive plural subject)
- g. b^{fi}us-e-fiĩ-ka
run-1PL-PROG-EXC
(1st person exclusive plural subject)

The marker appears in the same position in transitive verbs, preceding non-1st person number markers. A complication arises in the 1 → 2 forms here, where we see reduplication of the first syllable of the tense-agreement sequence rather than the expected metathesis. This is not seen, however, in the dual form.

(107) *Selected progressive forms of tse-ma ‘to teach’*³³

- a. tsjat-ʌ-fiĩ
teach-NPST.3O-PROG
(3rd person singular subject, 3rd person singular object)
- b. tset-i-fiĩ-na
teach-NPST-PROG-2
(3rd person singular subject, 2nd person singular object)
- c. tset-i-fiĩ-tsi
teach-NPST-PROG-NSG
(3rd person singular subject, 1st person inclusive dual object)
- d. tset-u-fiĩ-tsu
teach-NPST-PROG-DUS
(1st person inclusive dual subject, 3rd person singular object)

³²In some varieties, this is realised as *-gĩ*, and may be compared to the Nachhiring marker *-gəŋ*. (Grollmann 2018) The sound-change *g* → *fi* is unexpected, however.

³³These forms show a metaphonic alternation between /e/ and /ja/ not shown by all speakers.

- e. tsjat-u-fiã-num
teach-NPST-PROG-2PLS
(2nd person plural subject, 3rd person object)
- f. tsjat-Λ-m-fiã-ka
teach-NPST.3O-1PLS-PROG-EXC
(1st person exclusive plural subject, 3rd person object)
- g. tse-n-i-fiã-n-i
teach-1→2-NPST-PROG-1→2-NPST
(1st person subject, 2nd person singular object)
- h. tse-n-i-fiã-n-i-ni
teach-1→2-NPST-PROG-1→2-NPST-2PLO
(1st person subject, 2nd person plural object)
- i. tse-n-i-fiã-tsi-na
teach-1→2-NPST-PROG-NSG-2
(1st person subject, 2nd person dual object)

The meaning of the progressive is quite similar to its English counterpart, except that (like its Nepali counterpart in *-dai*) it is only used with *dynamic* (i.e. non-stative) predicates. It is compatible with either past or non-past tense.

7.3.4 Light verb constructions

Another type of compound verb is composed of a noun and a light verb (i.e. a verb which does not contribute semantic content of its own). Generally speaking the semantic content of the predicate here comes from the noun, with the identity of the verb depending solely on the transitivity of the predicate – if transitive, the verb is generally *mo-ma* ‘do’, while intransitives surface with the verb *ts^hu-ma* ‘become’.

A specialisation of this latter category is used when borrowing Nepali verbal elements – in this case the Nepali verb stem surfaces, together with a ‘nativising’ final vowel *-a*, and is combined with *mo-ma* ‘do’ or *ts^hu-ma* ‘become’, depending on transitivity as above.

- (108) a. *Intransitive verb* (← Nepali *pher-nu* ‘to change’)

k^hΛka gabisΛ-mi nuŋ=sã p^her-a ts^h-a-kΛ tu-i
and VDC-GEN name=too **change-fv** **become**-PST-LNK sit-NPST

‘And even the name of the V[illage] D[evelopment] C[ommittee] has changed.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

- b. *Transitive verb* (← Nepali *padh-nu* ‘to read, study’)

[...] pΛq^h-a mu-si kus-ã
[...] **study-fv** **do**-PURP come.down-1SG

‘[...] I came down to study’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

7.4 Non-finite forms

7.4.1 Infinitives

Infinitives are formed by attaching *-ma* to the verb stem. This is the verb form which is typically offered as citation forms and appear as the verb form in various types of complement clause.

- (109) pΛila luŋtsa b^hΛ-**ma** ts^h-i
first millet boil-**INF** become-NPST

‘First you have to boil millet.’ (Beer Making 08/09/21)

Infinitives also serve as bases for certain ‘participles’ and ‘converbs’ (see the following sections).

7.4.2 Purposives

Purposives, in particular purposive complements – that is to say, clauses which express the reason for which an action is undertaken – are formed by attaching *-si* to the verb stem.

(110) Purposive marker

[...] pʌd^h-a mu-**si** kus-ã
[...] study-FV do-**PURP** come.down-1SG

‘[...] I came down to study’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

Purposive adjunct clauses are more typically formed using the infinitive and the postposition *lagi* ‘for’

7.4.3 Participles

Forms which I label participles³⁴ here can be formed by combining an inflected verb form or an infinitive with the ‘linking’ suffix *-ka*. A typical use for a participle is in the formation of relative clauses. Generally speaking, object relatives (whether a direct object or an indirect object) will appear with finite participles, while subject relatives make use of infinitival participles. Subject relatives also show an (apparently optional) alternative form of the linking suffix, *-ki*.³⁵ All this is shown in the following examples:

(111) Object Relative

mʌkʌ mina ŋʌs-ʌ-**kʌ** wadi
that person fry-NPST.3O-**LNK** egg

‘The egg that that person will fry’

(112) Subject Relative

wadi ŋã-ma-**ki** mina
egg fry-INF-**LNK** person

‘The person who fried/will fry an egg’

(113) Applied Object Relative

kã wadi ŋã-pj-ã-**kʌ** mina
1SG egg fry-APPL-NPST.3O.1SGS-**LNK** person

‘The person who I will fry an egg for’

(114) Causee Relative

kã k^hã-mi-ŋ-**kʌ** mina
1SG look.at-CAUS-1SGS-**LNK** person

‘The person who I showed a house to’

³⁴The label is not intended to have any deep import here – these forms are used in broadly similar contexts to Nepali forms which are conventionally labelled participles, and the label is intended to reflect this fact. It should be noted that the *morphology* of these forms is rather distinct.

³⁵I suspect this may be related to the agentive nominalizer *-kabi*, but I do not have strong evidence on this point.

7.4.4 *Converbs*

I use the term *converb* to refer to verbal forms which form adverbial clauses with a range of relations to the main clause (cf. Haspelmath 1995) – the relation implied may be simply temporal or explicitly causal in nature. The most frequent form of this type is formed by combining an inflected verb form or an infinitive with the suffix *-ma*. The elements formed in this way may or may not share a subject with the main verb.

(115) *Same-Subject Converbial Clause*

k^hΛkalama t^hΛpa=lo jumpa tu-e-ka-**ma** bana dz^hΛ-m-e-ka-kΛ
 then up=COM down sit-1PL-EXC-**CONV** projectile throw-RECIP-1PL-EXC-LNK

‘Then we’d sit at the top and bottom and throw projectiles at each other.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

(116) *Different Subject Converbial Clause*

sjelama ts^hinda=tsahĩ p^heri D^hΛran-a=pi ã=bã kants^ha
 tomorrow day.after.tomorrow=TOP again Dharan-FV=LOC 1SG.POSS=uncle(FyB) youngest.brother
 kats^h-ã-**ma** paq^h-a mu-si kus-ã
 call-PST.1SGO-**CONV** study do-PURP go.down-1SG

‘Not long after, my father’s youngest brother invited me to Dharan and I went there to study.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

We also sometimes see an apparently synonymous (though less common in my data) converbial suffix *-hã*.

A converbial form specifically used for *depictive*, *simultaneous* events is formed with the suffix *-to*, and may be attached directly to a stem or to an inflected form.

- (117) ã=sat^hi [...] =bo=tsahĩ pai-**to** pai-**to** tuw-a-j-a
 1SG.POSS=friend [PN]=CONTR.TOP₃=CONTR.TOP₂ scream-CONV.SIM scream-CONV.SIM sit-PST-CONT-PST
 ‘As for my friend [name], he was sitting there screaming and screaming.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

When attached to verbal stems denoting property concepts, this results in an ‘adverbial’ reading. Hence the form *k^hann-i-to*, derived from the verb stem *k^hann-* ‘be good’, is best translated ‘well’.

The simultaneous converb *-to* may be combined with a negator to indicate the interval in which a state does not hold.

- (118) k^hΛpikalama meni it-ta barsadi=pi paka mo-ma-ma pok-i-nã-**to**
 then over.there one-CL rain.cover=LOC bundle do-INF-CONV.SEQ rise-NPST-**NEG-CONV.SIM**
 it-ta kuna=pi ju-ma ts^h-i
 one-CL corner=LOC put-INF become-NPST

‘Then we have to pack it in a rain cover and put it over in a corner until it is ready. [lit. ‘while it does not rise’]’ (Beer Making 08/09/21)

A special negative converb may be formed using the suffix *-mampa*.

- (119) t^hulo dzanti khai-**mampa** p^heri dui k^hepa b^hja ts^h-i
 big wedding.procession go-**NEG.CONV** then two time marriage become-NPST
 ‘Before you have a big wedding procession, then the marriage takes place two times.’ (lit. while one has not gone on a big wedding procession...; Marriage Traditions, rav15, 20/07/25)

7.4.5 Conditionals

Conditionals are formed by attaching the suffix $-d^h\tilde{\Lambda}$ to an inflected verb form.

- (120) ana nΛkΛ lun dz^hΛla=pi tj-Λ-na-**d^hΛ̃** nΛkΛ dz^hΛla pit-i
 2SG this stone bag=LOC put-3O.NPST-2-COND this bag tear-NPST
 ‘If you put this stone in the bag, this bag will tear.’ (Dahl TMA Questionnaire #79)

We do not see a robust distinction between factual and counter-factual conditional clauses.

7.4.6 Other subordinate forms

Specifically temporal subordination, especially where subjects are distinct, may be expressed using the affix $-lo$, attached to an inflected verb form.³⁶

- (121) k^hO nΛpi tuw-a-**lo** kΛ̃ t-u-ŋ-kΛ
 3SG here sit-PST-when 1SG see-PST.3O-1SGS-LNK
 ‘When he was here, I saw him’

This element may be related to the comitative marker and coordinator $-lo$, and is also present in the temporal interrogative *fiallo* ‘when?’

A form which may be translated using clauses headed by ‘like’ or ‘as if’ involves the suffix $-tika$, attached directly to an inflected verb form.

The element *pa^{ts}^hi*, borrowed from Nepali, may likewise be attached directly to an inflected verb form.

8 Syntax

8.1 Word order

Like almost all languages of the region, Sampang displays an unmarked SOV word-order in transitive clauses, which is the order that tends to be offered in translation-based elicitation.

- (122) *Unmarked SOV order from elicitation*

Λ̃=nuts^ha=wa ci^ht^hi ts^hab-Λ-**fi**Λ̃
 1SG.POSS=younger.brother=ERG letter write-NPST.3O-PROG
 ‘My brother is writing letters.’ (Dahl TMA Questionnaire #5)

Like neighbouring languages, however, this word order shows a great deal of flexibility, conditioned by information-structural properties (which have not yet been thoroughly investigated). For example, both of the following sentences were offered in elicitation:

- (123) *Alternation between SOV and OSV in elicitation*

a. *SOV order*

sΛbΛi fioga = tsi = wa um=malik-a=tsi=lai k^hΛ-tsi
 all dog=NSG=ERG 3SG.POSS=OWNER-FV=NSG=DAT bite-NSG.O
 ‘All the dogs bit their owners.’

b. *OSV order*

um=malik-a=tsi=lai sΛbΛi fioga = tsi = wa k^hΛ-tsi
 3SG.POSS=OWNER-FV=NSG=DAT all dog=NSG=ERG bite-NSG.O
 ‘All the dogs bit their owners.’

³⁶I distinguish this from other converbial forms as the meaning of this form is not ambiguous between temporal and causal relations in the same way as other converbs.

Additionally, due to widespread argument drop (discussed further in the next subsection), it is difficult to find SOV sentences with all arguments realised in natural speech. Below is a selection of word orders observed in natural speech, with omitted arguments underlined in the translation.

(124) *Word order in natural speech*

a. *All arguments omitted*

fiallo-sã matt-ã-s-ã-nã

when-too forget₁-NPST.3O.1SGS-forget₂-NPST.3O.1SGS-NEG

‘I will never forget it.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

b. *OV (S omitted)*

paila [O luŋtsa] b^hΛ-ma ts^h-i

first millet boil-INF become-NPST

‘First we have to boil millet’ (Beer Making 08/09/21)

c. *SV (O omitted) [Embedded Clause]*

...d^hΛran-a = pi [S ã-bã kants^ha] kats^h-ã-ma ...

...Dharan-FV=LOC 1SG.POSS-uncle(FyB) youngest.brother call-1SGO.PST-CONV ...

‘...when my father’s youngest brother invited me to Dharan ...’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

d. *SV (intransitive)*

k^hΛka [S gabisa-mi nuŋ-sã] p^her-a ts^ha-ka tu-i

then VDC-GEN name-too change-FV become-LNK sit-NPST

‘And even the V[illage]D[evelopment]C[ommittee]’s name has changed.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

e. *OSV*

ts^hΛ sat barsΛ-ka tuw-ã-ka bela [O d^hami ts^hu-ma-ka itta k^hela] [S kaeka]

six seven year-LNK sit-1SG-LNK time shaman become-INF-LNK one game 1PL.EXC]

lo=sã wal-e-ts-e-ka

when=too play-1PL-DUR-1PL-EXC

‘When I was six or seven years old, we’d always play a game of being shamans.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

f. *SOV*

ã=nid^har-a=pi [S maka kuriŋ luŋ=wa] [O kã=lai] t^h-ã-ka tuw-a

1SG.POSS=forehead-FV=LOC that pebble stone=ERG 1SG=DAT hit-PST.1SGO-LNK sit-PST

‘Those pebbles had hit me on the forehead.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

Similarly, while indirect objects (goals, causees) tend to precede direct objects (themes, patients) in ditransitive forms in translation, this is likewise flexible.

(125) *Default IO-DO order*

kã pi=lai wãkep ja-ŋ

1SG COW=DAT grass feed[PST.3O]-1SGS

‘I fed the cow grass.’

(126) *Alternative DO-IO order*

kãŋa=wa jawa=lai nuwak^him pas-u-ŋ

1SG=ERG child=DAT school send-PST.3O-1SGS

‘I sent that child to school.’

As the examples in (124) show, arguments in Sampang may be dropped relatively freely, regardless of their grammatical role.

Omitted arguments may have definite, indefinite or generic interpretations. In the case of indefinite or generic interpretations, we often see plural agreement, even when the assumed referent is singular.

(127) *Argument drop in Sampang*

a. *Definite*

sj-a-dur-a

die-PST-COMPL-PST

‘He has [already] died.’ (Dahl TMA Questionnaire #56)

b. *Indefinite*

radza=lai sit-u-tsi-ka

king=DAT kill-PST.3O-NSG-LNK

‘They (indef.) killed the king.’ (Dahl TMA Questionnaire #57)

Argument drop is pervasive in natural speech.

8.2 The Syntax of Agreement

8.2.1 Restrictions on Agreement

Agreement typically only occurs with animate arguments, and only *obligatorily* with human arguments (subject to various morphological factors, outlined above). When a morphologically transitive verb does not agree with an object (either because the object is inanimate or because we have a mismatch between morphological and syntactic transitivity, as outlined below), it typically surfaces with a default agreement suffix. This default suffix, illustrated in (128b) is generally identical to third person singular object agreement (and is glossed as such throughout this sketch), but may trigger different morphophonological alternations – in particular, the verb *mo-ma* ‘to do’ has a different stem (*mi-*) before object agreement proper as compared to the stem (*m(u)-*) which appears with default agreement. This is illustrated in (128c, 128d).³⁷

(128) *Object agreement vs. Default Agreement*

a. *Object agreement with animate (indirect) object*

(...) mākā sat^hi=tsi=lai dui dui dana āp-a pj-u-tsi

(...) that friend=NSG=DAT two two CL.FRUIT mango-FV give-PST.3O-NSG

‘He gave those friends two mangoes each.’ (Pear Story, rav1 11/07/25)

b. *Default (=3sg) agreement with no animate object*

itta mina āp-a bit-u

one person mango-FV pick-PST.3O[DEF]

‘A person picked mangoes.’ (Pear Story, rav1 11/07/25)

c. *Allomorphy of moma (animate object)*

kā at^hepa ā=ts^ha nuh-a mi-ŋ

1SG yesterday 1SG.POSS=child bathe-FV do(PST.3O)-1SGS

‘I bathed my child yesterday’

d. *Allomorphy of moma (no true object)*

³⁷The morphology here is rather complex and may bear some elucidation. First, although the predicate *nuha mo-ma* is syntactically labile, it is unambiguously morphologically transitive, as can be seen from the form of the 1sg affix *-ŋ*, in contrast to intransitive *-ā*. The use of the light verb *moma* ‘do’ (as opposed to intransitive *ts^huma* ‘become’) also signals this. As a reviewer points out, it is not actually clear whether the 3rd person object suffix actually surfaces in either example here, as the default stem ending in *mu-* ends in the same vowel. With other verbs, this is unambiguous – but with other verbs we do not see the stem alternation between ‘true’ agreement and the default form that we see with *mo-ma*.

kã at^hepa nuh-a m-u-ŋ
 1SG yesterday bathe-FV do-PST.3O[DEF]-1SGS
 ‘I bathed yesterday’

A verb may show at most one object agreement marker – as we will see, this *does not* imply that a verb may only agree with one object.

The agreement morphology on verbs is closely correlated with the number of arguments a verb takes, but this correlation is not perfect. For example, motion verbs may take a bare nominal argument (the goal) but do not display transitive agreement.³⁸ There are two verbs that can broadly be translated ‘say’ or ‘call’, where one (*gu-ma*) displays intransitive agreement morphology and the other (*lo-ma*) displays transitive agreement morphology. Morphological reflexives show intransitive agreement marking (albeit modified) even when an additional object argument is present. Certain unergative predicates (which may alternate with transitives) show transitive agreement despite lacking an object – *nuh-a mo-ma* ‘bathe’ in (128) is one such predicate. Verbs that take subjectlike arguments in atypical case forms (e.g. dative) usually do not agree with those arguments, either as subjects or objects.³⁹ Such verbs may be morphologically transitive or intransitive.

(129) *Valency/Agreement Mismatches*

a. *Motion verbs*

kã nuwak^him k^hat-ã
 1SG school go-1SG(INTR)
 ‘I went to school’

b. *Verbs of saying*

nɬkɬ = lai jã g-i-mi/l-ɬ-tsi
 this=DAT what say₁-NPST-3PL(INTR)/say₂-NPST.3O-NSGS
 ‘What does one call this?’

c. *Reflexives*

k^ho Sampan tse-n-i-fiã-tsi
 3SG Sampang learn-REFL-NPST-PROG-NSG(INTR)
 ‘S/he is learning Sampang’

d. *Unergatives*

kã at^hepa nuh-a m-u-ŋ
 1SG yesterday bathe-FV do-PST.3O[DEF]-1SGS
 ‘I bathed yesterday’

e. *Dative subjects*

kã=lai saka lo
 1SG=DAT hunger feel.PST.3O
 ‘I feel hungry.’

While this last example shows an interaction between case-marking and agreement, there is no uncomplicated link between the two properties. We may see object agreement with elements marked with dative case, comitative case or absolutive case. We may see transitive subject agreement with elements marked with either ergative or absolutive case. It does however seem to be a true generalisation that we do not see subject agreement (whether transitive or intransitive) with elements marked with dative or comitative case.

³⁸A reviewer questions whether this should be analysed as an adjunct or an argument. As Sampang does not generally allow bare absolutive nouns to serve as adjuncts I believe it is correct to analyse it as an argument.

³⁹As an aside, it is interesting to note that these constructions constitute an exception to Bickel’s (2004) generalisation that Kiranti languages lack overtly marked versions of what he calls ‘experiencer-as-goal’ constructions. This is no doubt a consequence of contact with Nepali. However, while the dative case-marker is ultimately borrowed from Nepali, it is thoroughly integrated into Sampang grammar and is used by all generations. In terms of agreement properties, non-agreeing arguments like this are noted (albeit without the dative case marking) by Bickel in languages such as Belhare. Thanks to a reviewer for pointing out the relevance of Bickel’s paper.

The former can be seen in (129e) – it is difficult to find clear examples of comitative subjectlike arguments,, but might be seen in e.g. possessive constructions.⁴⁰

(130) *No agreement in possessive forms*

kã=lo kalam tu-i
1SG=COM pen sit-NPST

‘I have a pen.’

This is in addition to the facts above whereby certain modals and auxiliaries agree with a verb and others do not.

8.2.2 Agreement in Ditransitive Constructions

As noted above, Sampang allows agreement marking with at most two arguments in its verbal complex, which raises the interesting question of which arguments agree in a ditransitive clause, where there are three arguments. Sampang possesses a few different types of ditransitive verbs:

- a) Underived ditransitive verbs - of these, the most common are *pi-ma* ‘to give’ and *ha-ma* ‘to send’.
- b) Causative verbs – causatives of monotransitives exhibiting the causativising affix *-me-*: e.g. *k^hã-me-ma* ‘to show’ (causative of *k^hã-ma* ‘to look’)
- c) Applicative verbs – applicatives of monotransitives

(131) *Types of Ditransitive Verb in Sampang*

a. kã-ŋa ã-mi bumi=lai bulu pi-ŋ
1SG-FOC 1SG.POSS-GEN friend=DAT money give(PST.3O)-1SG.S

‘I gave money to my friend.’

b. kãŋa=wa bumi=lai ru k^hã-mi-ŋ
1SG=ERG friend=DAT letter look-CAUS(PST.3O)-1SG.S

‘I showed the letter to [my] friend.’

c. kã ana=lai wadi ñã-pi-n-i
1SG 2SG=DAT egg fry-APPL-1→2-NPST

‘I will fry you an egg.’

A typical underived ditransitive using ‘give’ or ‘send’ takes one animate indirect object and one inanimate direct object. This means that we generally only see agreement with the indirect object/goal, as in (131c), since inanimate nouns are not licit targets for agreement.

In cases where we do have two animate objects, which are typically causatives of transitive verbs taking an animate object, there are two possibilities:

- a) The form is derived from a *symmetric* predicate, i.e. one where *x* V-ing *y* implies that *y* Vs *x* (e.g. ‘fight’ – if X fights Y, then Y fights X).
- b) The form is derived from an *asymmetric* predicate, where there is no such implication. (e.g. ‘see’ – if X sees Y, then Y may not see X).

In each of these cases, there is usually a degree of optionality in the agreement that results. In case a), the verb may (but does not need to) agree with both arguments. This results in *summative* resolved agreement, which will be discussed further shortly. In case b), the verb only agrees with one argument, but which argument may be agreed with depends both on the person and the grammatical role of the arguments involved.

⁴⁰ As a reviewer points out, it may not be entirely convincing to suppose that the possessor here is indeed subjectlike. Further work is necessary to unpick the diagnostics of subjecthood in Sampang, if indeed such a notion is coherent in the language.

For example, the causative of the verb *jam-ma* ‘to hit’ is *jam-me-ma* ‘to make hit’. If the embedded agent is third person and the embedded patient is first person then either third person or first person object agreement markers may surface. On the other hand, if the embedded agent is first person and the embedded patient is third person, third person agreement with the embedded patient is blocked.

- (132) a. Ram=wa Sjame=lai l-u-ma kã=lai jam-mj-ã/(jam-mj-u)
 Ram-ERG Shyame=DAT tell-PST.3O-CONV 1SG=DAT hit-CAUS-PST.1SGO(/hit-CAUS-PST.3O)
 ‘Ram got Shyame to hit me by telling him to.’ (either 3rd or 1st person licit)
- b. Ram=wa kã=lai l-ã-ma jam-mj-ã/(jam-mj-u)
 Ram-ERG 1SG=DAT tell-PST.1SGO-CONV hit-CAUS-PST.1SGO(/hit-CAUS-PST.3O)
 ‘Ram got me to hit him by telling me to.’

This contrasts with forms which make use of symmetric predicates, which, while they may have agreement with a single argument as we see in (132), optionally display an unusual kind of *resolved* agreement. This resolution involves both number features and person features (see Perry 2024).

- (133) a. *Resolution for person features*
- | | | | | |
|--------------------------------------|-------------|-------------|----------|----------|
| ↓Obj ₁ Obj ₂ → | 1inc | 1exc | 2 | 3 |
| 1inc | N/A | N/A | 1inc | 1inc |
| 1exc | N/A | N/A | 1inc | 1exc |
| 2 | 1inc | 1inc | N/A | 2 |
| 3 | 1inc | 1exc | 2 | 3 |
- b. *Resolution for number features*
- | | | | |
|--------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|
| ↓Obj ₁ Obj ₂ → | Sg | Du | Pl |
| Sg | Du | Pl | Pl |
| Du | Pl | Pl | Pl |
| Pl | Pl | Pl | Pl |

This is illustrated in (134), where we see resolution between a first person singular object and a third person dual object, resulting in first person plural exclusive agreement.

- (134) Gita=wa kã=lai um=pama=lo tup-m-e-ka
 Gita-ERG 1SG=DAT 3SG.POSS=parents=COM meet-CAUS-1PL.ABS-EXC
 ‘Gita introduced me to her parents’

While neither of the individual object arguments here is first person plural exclusive – indeed, plural number appears on neither argument – the *sum* of these arguments is first person exclusive (i.e. includes the speaker, but not the addressee), and plural (includes more than two individuals). This is comparable to the resolved agreement we see with coordination in English. In this case, however, the arguments are not in a coordination relation. As far as I am aware, such a system is not attested outside Sampang.

8.2.3 Infinitival Agreement

Infinitives generally lack agreement in Sampang but under certain circumstances they may surface with nominal (i.e. possessive) agreement markers, in particular when they appear on complements of *lo-ma* ‘feel, want’. If the embedded verb is intransitive, this nominal agreement appears directly on the infinitival verb. If they are transitive, it may optionally appear on the first object if it is a full noun or otherwise on the verb.

- (135) *Infinitival Agreement*
- a. *Intransitive verb*
- ã=bai-ma lo
 1SG.POSS=come-INF want.PST
 ‘I want to come.’
- b. *Transitive verb with pronominal object*

k^hosa kã=lai um=jam-ma lo-kA tu-i
 1SG.ERG 1SG=DAT 3SG.POSS=hit-INF want.PST-LNK sit-NPST.3SG

‘He wants to hit me.’

c. (Di)transitive verb with nominal object

ã=mina=lai kitab-a pi-ma lo
 1SG.POSS=person=DAT book-FV give-INF want.PST

‘I want to give someone a book.’

Note that although the agreement on the infinitive is possessive, the subject of the infinitival verb itself bears a subject case (whether absolutive or ergative) if it surfaces. Infinitival agreement appears in general to be optional.

(136) *Infinitival constructions without agreement*

kã=lai mina tup-ma lo
 1SG=DAT person meet-INF want

‘I want to meet someone.’

8.2.4 Long-distance agreement

The two agreeing arguments of a typical Sampang transitive verb need not be clausemates. We see agreement of verbs with arguments of both finite and non-finite clauses. For example, we see optional agreement with the object of an infinitival clause in (137).

- (137) ana [kã=lai jam-ma] t^hal-a mj-ã-na (/m-u-na)
 2(SG) [1SG=DAT hit-INF] start-FV do-1SGO.PST-2S (/do-PST.3O-2S)
 ‘You began to hit me’

We can also see examples of object agreement with the *subject* of an embedded clause – an example of this is shown in (138).

- (138) [kã at^hepa k^hat-ã-kA-d^hã] k^hosa nat-ã-kA
 1SG(ABS) yesterday go-1SG-LNK-COND 3SG.ERG like-1SGO.PST-LNK
 ‘He wanted me to go yesterday’

The precise distribution of long-distance agreement remains a subject for investigation.

8.3 The Syntax of Case Marking

Like most languages of the region Sampang shows a pattern of differential object marking *and* differential subject marking. Subjects of transitive verbs may be marked with the ergative/instrumental marker *-wa*, while animate objects are typically marked with the dative suffix *-lai*.

- (139) ã=nid^har-a=pi maK^hA kuriŋ luŋ=wa kã=lai t^h-ã-kA tuw-a
 1SG=forehead-FV=LOC that pebble stone=ERG 1SG=DAT hit-PST.1SGO-LNK sit-PST
 ‘Those pebbles hit me on the forehead.’ (Childhood Memories 08/07/2021)

Certain verbs take objects with comitative case (e.g. *lai-ma* ‘ask’, *m^hã-ma* ‘fight’, *tup-ma* ‘meet’).

- (140) kã k^ho=lo m^h-u-ŋ
 1SG 3SG-COM fight-PST.3O-1SGS
 ‘I fought him.’

Certain verbs have a subjectlike argument which takes an objectlike case. These arguments can be distinguished from ordinary objects by their neutral word order as well as by the fact that they do not trigger agreement, as discussed in §8.2.1.

- (141) $k\tilde{\lambda}$ =**lai** saka lo
 1SG=**DAT** hunger feel.[PST.3O]
 ‘I feel hungry.’

More work is required to determine the exact distribution of ergative case marking in natural speech. This is made somewhat difficult by the free argument drop that Sampang displays – subjects are typically not expressed overtly. What is clear, however, is that subjects of transitive verbs need not display ergative marking. An example drawn from spontaneous speech is given in (142):

- (142) *Non-obligatory ergative marking in Sampang*

matto bela=pi **d^hami=wa** um=sir-a ts^h o=pi ti-u-k λ mak λ m λ dzur-a **kaeka=tsahĩ**
 such time=LOC shaman=ERG 3SG=head-FV top=LOC wear-PST.3O-LNK that peacock-FV 1PL.EXC=TOP
 titepati-mi banmara-mi mu-ŋ-ka-ma ti-ŋ-ka-k λ tuw-a
 artemesia-GEN eupatorium-GEN make-1PLS-EXC-CONV wear-1PLS-EXC-LNK sit-PST

“We made the peacock crown that a shaman would wear on his head at that time out of artemesia and eupatorium, then wore it” (Childhood Memories 08/07/21)

Here we see two overt transitive subjects *d^hami=wa* ‘shaman=ERG’ and *kaeka=tsahĩ* (1PL.EXC=TOP), which are arguments of identical lexical items in the same tense (past), both in participial form, but where the first displays ergative case and the latter does not. This may reflect a tendency that can be observed in elicited speech, whereby third person arguments tend to be ergative-marked and first and second person arguments tend not to be – consider the pairs in (143):

- (143) *Possible person effects in Sampang case marking*

- a. k^h o-sa at^hepa tsa tso
 3SG-ERG yesterday rice eat.PST.3O
 ‘S/he ate rice yesterday.’
 b. $k\tilde{\lambda}$ at^hepa tsa ts-u-ŋ
 1SG(ABS) yesterday rice eat-PST.3O-1SGS
 ‘I ate rice yesterday.’

The examples given are the speaker’s initial translations – when asked for judgements, however, he stated that ergative case could be dropped in (143a) and would be allowed in (143b). This suggests that the person-based effect is at most a tendency, and the conditions under which it holds or may be voided remain unclear.

9 Notes on Lexis

9.1 Lexical Borrowing

Sampang is in ongoing and intense contact with Nepali. This has had a substantial impact on the structure and lexis of the language. Perhaps the most noticeable impact of language contact with Nepali in Sampang is the very large number of Nepali borrowings in the language, including for quite basic vocabulary items, substantially outnumbering the Tibeto-Burman lexis.

Although Sampang belongs to the Central-Eastern group of Kiranti languages (to use the terminology of Bickel and Gaenszle 2015; cf. also Grollman and Gerber 2018), a non-negligible amount of basic vocabulary appears to be connected with Western Kiranti languages such as neighbouring Dumi and Koyi. For example, The word for ‘body’ is *riram* as in Dumi, cf. the more closely related Kulung *gam*. The word for ‘claw’ or ‘fingernail’ is *sendi*, comparable to Dumi *syendi* (cf. Kulung *sen*). The topic particle *bo* (translateable by Nepali *cāhĩ*) is comparable to its Dumi analogue *bæ* (Kulung *-ka*). The word for head is *lak^hala*, which

appears comparable to Dumi *dəkhlə* (cf. Kulung *ton*, whose Sampang cognate *tã* means ‘hair’). The word for ‘money’, *bulu*, is identical to Koyi *bulu* (Lahaussais 2009) and also resembles Dumi *bili*.⁴¹

The words for ‘good’ and ‘bad’ are *k^hann-i-ka* and *k^hais-i-ka* respectively, which appear to be comparable to Dumi *khəni-kpa* and *khəji-kpa* (van Driem 1993), Koyi *k^hanu?-pa*, *k^hai?-pa* (Lahaussais 2009), cf. the more closely related Kulung *nəpa*, *mannəpa*. In this last case, it does not seem impossible that the direction of borrowing is reversed – in Bantawa (Doornenbal 2009) similar forms seem to be compositional, possibly composed of a root meaning ‘look’ (cf. Sampang *k^hã-ma*) with a root cognate to the form found in Kulung.⁴² If the Sampang, Dumi and Koyi forms have a similar origin, the source cannot be Western Kiranti, which displays an unaspirated initial in the root for ‘look’.

9.2 Motion Verbs

Sampang motion verbs are a particularly systematic and quite elaborate part of the lexicon – where languages such as English use ‘come’ or ‘go’, oriented towards or away from the perspectival centre of the clause (usually, the speaker), Sampang prefers to also specify vertical direction (see Jacques and Lahaussais 2023 for discussion of comparable facts in other Kiranti languages). The verb ‘come’ also has a neutral form *ta-ma*, which is preferred when denoting someone arriving from an unseen place. This give us a total of seven distinct motion verbs.

(144) Sampang motion verbs

	Away from Perspective	Towards Perspective
Ascending	<i>lai-ma</i>	<i>t^hΛ-ma</i>
Level	<i>k^hai-ma</i>	<i>bai-ma</i>
Descending	<i>d^hai-ma</i>	<i>ku-ma</i>
Neutral	–	<i>ta-ma</i>
	‘go’	‘come’

These forms have a series of lexical causative counterparts, translateable as ‘take’ or ‘bring’.

(145) Sampang causative motion verbs

	Away from Perspective	Towards Perspective
Ascending	<i>lai-ma</i>	<i>t^hΛ-ma</i>
Level	<i>k^hai-ma</i>	<i>bai-ma</i>
Descending	<i>d^hai-ma</i>	<i>ko-ma</i>
Neutral	–	<i>tai-ma</i>
	‘take’	‘bring’

It will be observed that for a number of these forms the infinitive is identical in both causative and non-causative forms. This is typically *not* true of forms of these verbs involving vowel-initial suffixes. The first person singular past forms of these verbs are shown in (146):

(146) 1st person singular of Sampang motion verbs

	Away from Perspective	Towards Perspective
Ascending	<i>lat-ã</i>	<i>t^han-ã</i>
Level	<i>k^hat-ã</i>	<i>ban-ã</i>
Descending	<i>d^hat-ã</i>	<i>kus-ã</i>
Neutral	–	<i>t-ã</i>
	‘go’	‘come’

⁴¹No ordinary Kulung term is attested here but the usual Central-Eastern form is *yan*, as in e.g. Bantawa (Doornenbal 2009), Yakkha (Schackow 2015), Limbu (van Driem 1987) and Yamphu (Rutgers 1998). This is likely linked to Kulung *ron*, glossed by Tolsma (2006) as ‘rupiya (archaic)’.

⁴²cf. *tsa-n-i-ka* ‘tasty’, which contains the root for ‘eat’, Sampang *tsa-ma*.

(147) 1st person singular past of Sampang causative motion verbs

	Away from Perspective	Towards Perspective
Ascending	lat-u-ŋ	t ^h a-ŋ
Level	k ^h aj-u-ŋ	baj-u-ŋ
Descending	d ^h at-u-ŋ	k-u-ŋ
Neutral	–	tat-u-ŋ
	‘take’	‘bring’

As can be seen, the prevocalic forms of these verbs are generally distinct, with the exception of the forms of *d^hai-ma* ‘go down, take down’. For most of the items which display an alternation between causative and non-causative forms (with the notable exception of *lai-ma*, which has undergone a complex series of analogical changes) the transitive form here is derivable from a form with an ancient applicative suffix *-t* (see e.g. Jacques 2017 for discussion). Sound changes such as Proto-Kiranti *tt → /j/ and Proto-Kiranti *kt → ∅ have obscured this, however.⁴³

10 Conclusion

This sketch has presented a first overview of the properties of the Sampang language. It will no doubt be evident that much remains to be done. For example:

- The presentation of the stress system given has a largely impressionistic basis. Confirming (or disconfirming) these proposals instrumentally is crucial. In general, a good understanding of the cues for stress in languages of Nepal is lacking, and an instrumental study of Sampang would be a step towards rectifying this.
- The understanding of Sampang phonology would be enhanced by studying its historical development and relation to other Kiranti varieties. Some work along these lines is being undertaken (Perry and Sevilla in prep.)
- The syntactic constraints on ergative case-marking and long-distance agreement are not yet well understood. A more detailed study of these phenomena will no doubt feed into a better understanding of the syntax of Sampang, as well as related and neighbouring languages.

This list is, of course, non-exhaustive. Most of all, it is desirable to develop a wider corpus of Sampang language use, not only to provide a broader empirical basis for description of the language, but to provide a documentary record and basis for revitalisation of this language. It is my hope that future researchers, including members of the Sampang community, will be able to make use of this sketch to assist in work of this kind.

⁴³These sound-changes are widely attested in Sampang verb stems. To just give one further example for each change: Sampang *fuj-* ‘burn’ corresponds to Proto-Kiranti *hutt-, while Sampang *d^ho-* ‘dig’ corresponds to Proto-Kiranti *tokt-, using Jacques’ (2017) reconstruction of Proto-Kiranti. These facts are further discussed in Perry and Sevilla (in prep.)

ABBREVIATIONS

1, 2, 3	1st, 2nd, 3rd person	ERG	Ergative case
SG	singular	ABS	Absolutive case
NSG	non-singular	DAT	Dative case
DU	dual	COM	Comitative case
PL	plural	LOC	Locative case
INC, EXC	inclusive, exclusive	GEN	Genitive case
PST, NPST	past tense, non-past tense	ABL	Ablative case
INF	infinitive	LNK	linker
CONV	converb	FOC	focus marker
CONV.SIM	simultaneous converb	CONTR.TOP	contrastive topic marker
S, O	subject agreement, object agreement	FC	final vowel
COMPL	completive aspect	CONT	continuous aspect
PROG	progressive aspect	DUR	durative aspect
IMP	imperative mood	OPT	optative mood
EXH	exhortative mood	COHORT	cohortative mood
POSS	possessive marker	CAUS	causative
APPL	applicative	TR	transitive
INTR	intransitive	REFL	reflexive
RECIP	reciprocal	1→2	1st person subject, 2nd person object
NEG	negation	COMP	comparative
COP	(essential) copula	INT	interrogative
MIR	mirative	PURP	purposive

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